The Objective Ledger

FOR TWO OR MORE · SHORT VERSION

The Objective Ledger

Understanding yourself and
the people you share a life with

FOR TWO OR MORE · SHORT VERSION



CHRISTIAN

Spread Love & Acceptance
spreadloveandacceptance.com

The Objective Ledger: For two or more, the short version.
By Christian. Spread Love & Acceptance.

This edition: October 2026. Made from the chapters at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, where they are kept up to date.

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Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in the scenes and examples are invented, built from common patterns. None of them is a real person or a testimonial.

Research mentioned in the chapters is listed, with links, in the research notes at the back and at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

How to use this book

This is a book about seeing what is really going on, in yourself and between people, without blaming anyone, and then changing one small thing. This copy holds 6 chapters in one part, in the short version. There is no wrong way in.

THE PARTS

> **Part Two: Between us.** One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

TWO SIZES OF EVERY CHAPTER

Every chapter comes in a short version (about 10 to 15 minutes) and a full version with the research, more examples and more to try. This is the short version. The full version is free at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book.

READ IN ORDER, OR BY NEED

Read it front to back like any book, or start with the chapter that fits what is going on. Each chapter ends with *What to remember*, *This connects to* (the chapters that explain it or put it to use, with page numbers) and *Put it to use*, with codes you can scan for the matching tool.

IN EVERY CHAPTER

- A short scene: a made-up moment from everyday life.
- **Words you could use**: sentences to say out loud.
- **Try this**: one small thing to do this week.
- **Common mix-ups**: easy mistakes, and what is closer to true.

THE SITE, THE PROGRAM AND PROFESSOR PUDDLES

The book has a free website with the tools and worksheets the chapters mention. Nothing you type there leaves your device, and there is no account. The **six-week program** (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01) puts Part Two to work a week at a time, and the **self path** does the same for Part One. **Professor Puddles**, the site's friendly guide, answers questions about the book's ideas.

GO GENTLY

Some chapters touch hard things: grief, shame, anger, worry, trauma. Skip anything that isn't right for today. Nothing here is a test, and nothing needs to be done all at once.

The book in two pictures

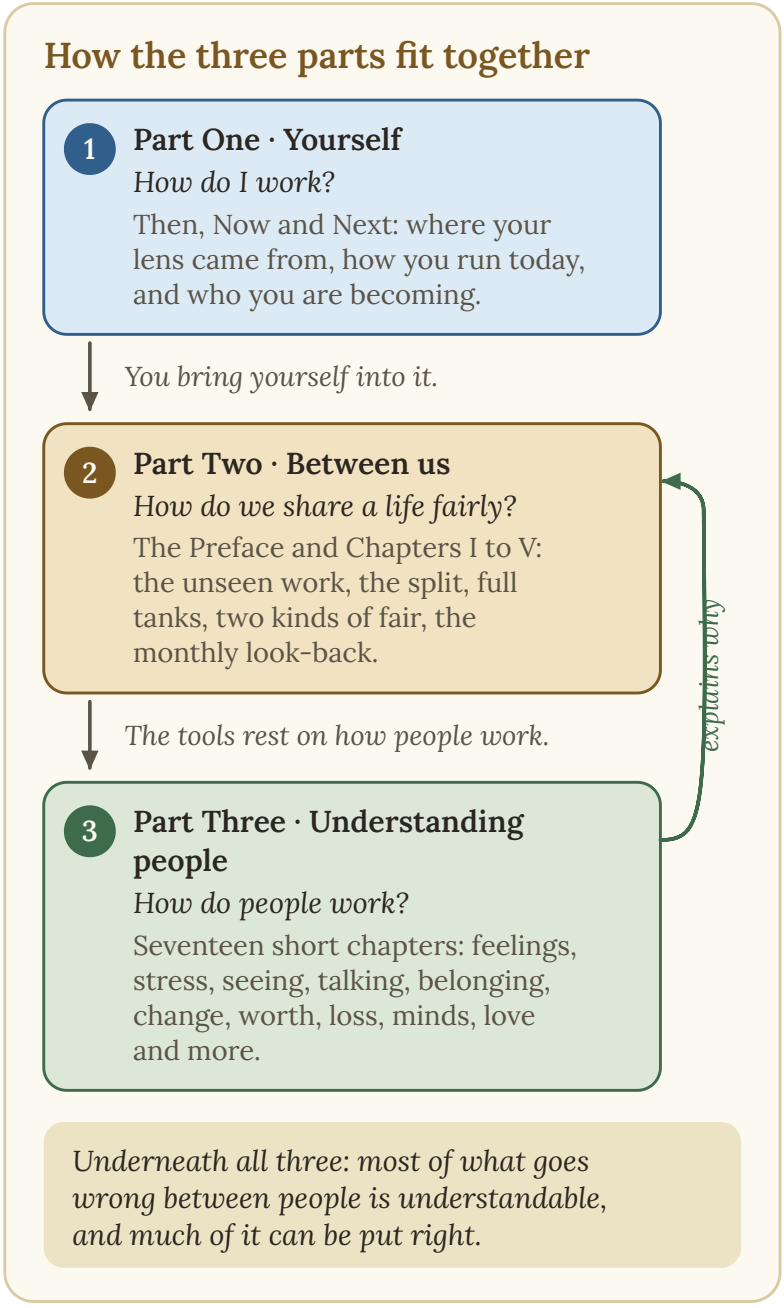


FIGURE 1 How the three parts fit together: you bring yourself into every shared life, and Part Three explains why the Part Two tools work.

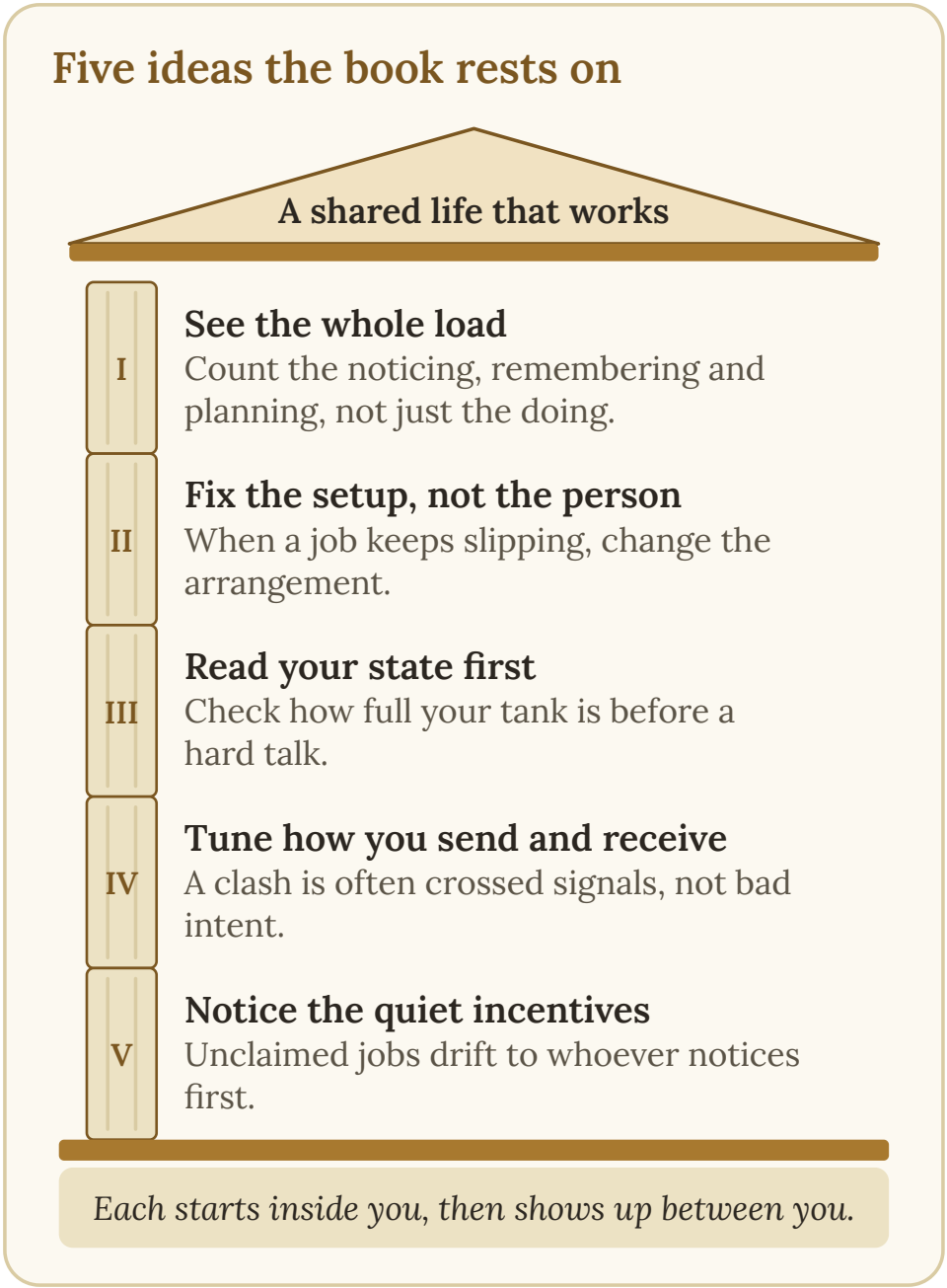


FIGURE 2 Five ideas the whole book rests on. Each one starts inside you, then shows up between you and the people you share a life with.

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PART TWO

Between us

One idea per chapter about sharing a life, a home or work with someone, each with a worksheet that puts it to use.

IN THIS PART

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Preface

PREFACE TO PART TWO

The work nobody sees: invisible labour at home

Part Two of the book is about the people you share a life, a home or a job with, and it opens here. Running a life takes a lot of work that nobody sees. This preface helps you make that work visible, to yourself and to anyone you share it with, so you can talk about it fairly and kindly.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Unseen work quietly adds up
2. A lot of it is thinking, not doing
3. The other person usually just hasn't seen it
4. Writing it down isn't keeping score
5. Each of you writes only your own side
6. The borrowed words are there to take the blame away
7. One small step at a time
8. It can help in many kinds of shared life
9. The mental load: what the research says
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: your own unseen work
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. Where this comes from: the polymath way
14. In real life
15. More kinds of shared life
16. Your situation, in this part of the book
17. Common mix-ups
18. Limits and cautions

IN SHORT:

- **Running a home takes unseen work:** the noticing, remembering and planning that many people call the mental load.
- **The other person usually just hasn't seen it.** This work hides by nature. It isn't a sign that they don't care.
- **Each of you writes only your own side** of one ordinary week, and you read the two lists together.

- **The list is for seeing, not for billing.** Thank each other for the past, and plan next week.

SUNDAY, 9PM

Someone notices the laundry is still in the washer, the school forms are due on Tuesday, and the birthday card never got posted. They also notice that nobody else has noticed. The house looks fine. That's the problem.

Or, living alone: A widower says, "Since my wife died, I notice how many jobs she quietly carried: the birthday cards, the boiler service, knowing who to ring when someone was ill. I never saw them until they stopped getting done."

01

Unseen work quietly adds up.

Remembering appointments, noticing the milk is low, calming a tense moment: none of it shows up on a calendar, so it rarely gets a thank-you. Over months, it piles up. The book calls this pile *unbilled debt*. Nobody sends a bill for it. You can thank someone for what they carried before; you just don't bill for the past.

For example: Marcus remembers every school form, dentist visit and bit of lunch money for their two kids. His husband, Theo, sees two kids who always seem to have what they need. The work is just out of sight.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can I show you some of the things I keep track of? I'm not asking you to pay anything back. I just want you to see them."

TRY THIS:

Tonight, write down three things you did today that nobody saw. Don't do anything with the list yet. Just notice.

02

A lot of it is thinking, not doing.

Before a job gets done, someone has to notice it, remember it, plan it and check it happened. That thinking takes real time and energy, even though nobody can see it.

For example: In a shared flat, Amira notices the internet deal is ending, compares plans, picks one and checks it went through. Paying took two minutes. The thinking took an evening.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Doing it is the quick part. Remembering it and planning it is the part I'd love some help with."

TRY THIS:
Pick one job at home and split it into four steps: notice, plan, do, check. Who usually does each step?

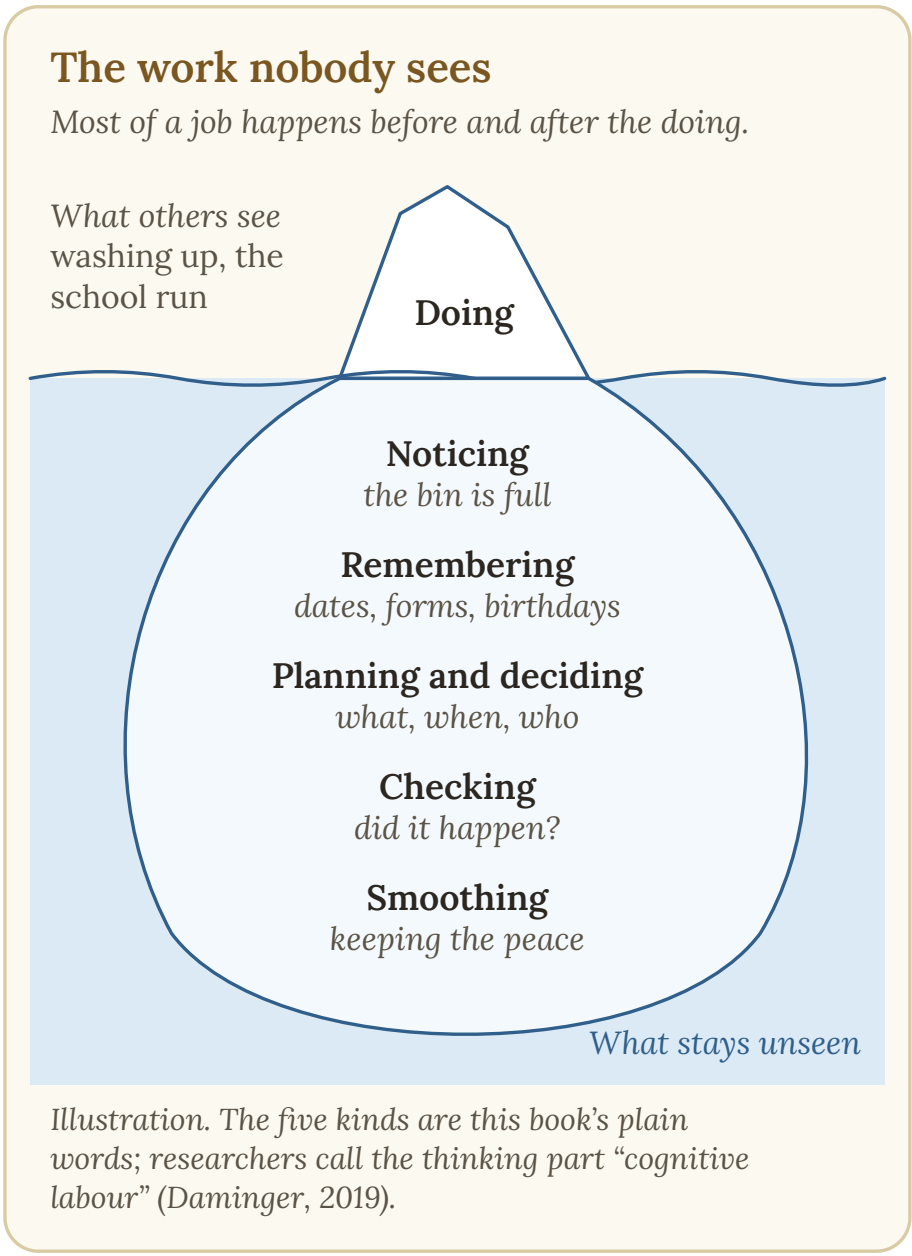


FIGURE 3 The work nobody sees. Most of a job happens before and after the doing, and whoever holds that part can never fully switch off.

03

The other person usually just hasn't seen it.

When this work is done well, nothing seems to happen. So the other person isn't ignoring it. From where they stand, it looks like things take care of themselves.

For example: Rose minds her grandchildren three afternoons a week and quietly moves her own doctor visits to fit. Her daughter thinks it all "fits in easily."

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't think you've been ignoring it. I think it's been hard to see from where you are."

TRY THIS:
Ask one person, "What's something you do that you think I don't see?" Then just listen, without explaining.

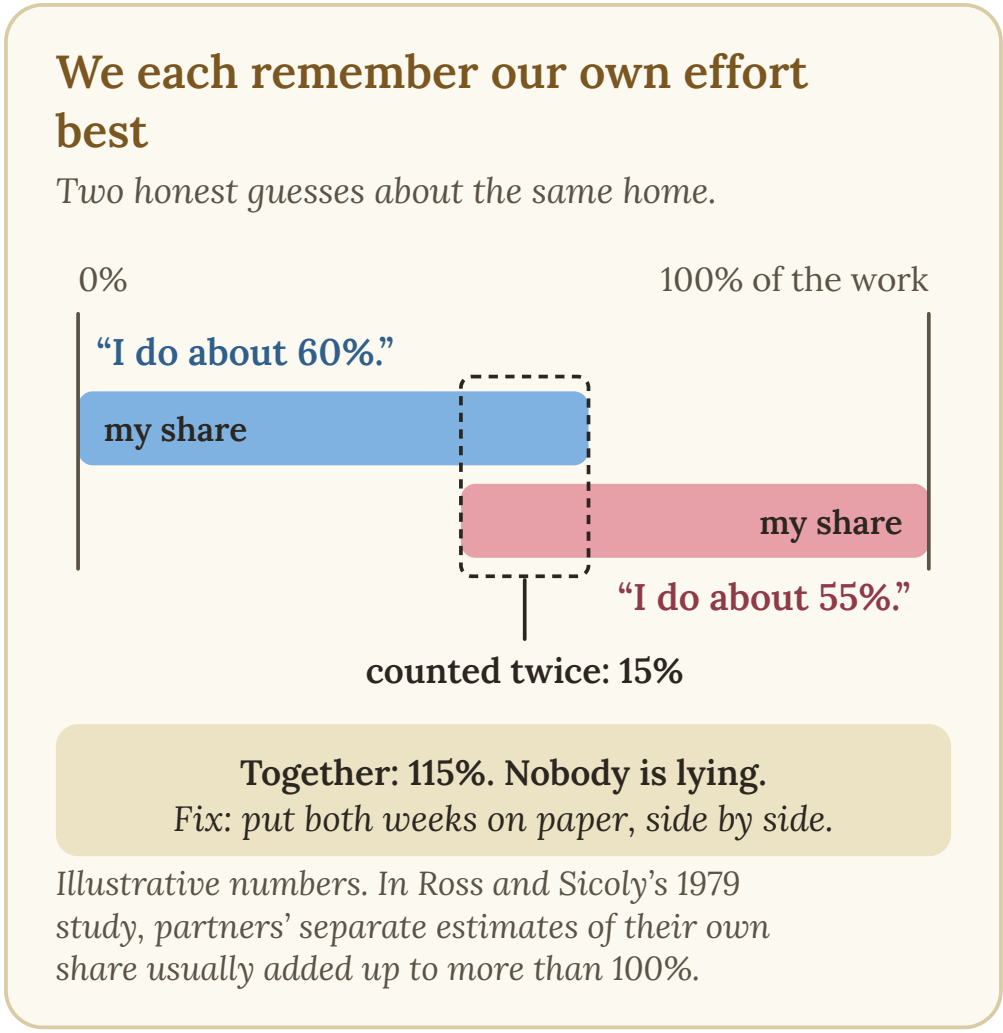


FIGURE 4 We each remember our own effort best. Illustrative numbers; in Ross and Sicoly's 1979 study, partners' estimates of their own share usually added up to more than 100 percent.

04

Writing it down isn't keeping score.

The point is for both of you to see the same picture, in the same words, at the same time. Then the talk starts from facts you share, not from two different memories.

The book calls this shared record a *ledger*: a plain list of who did what. It's a way to see, not a bill.

For example: Two coworkers sharing one job each list a week of tasks. Every client call landed on one person. They don't argue about last year; they swap Friday calls.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm not trying to win anything. I'd like us both to be looking at the same list."

TRY THIS:

Before you show anyone a list, ask yourself: is this to plan next week, or to prove a point? Share it only if the answer is "plan."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

Who did what

Marcus and Theo, a couple

Who did what

Person A
Marcus

Person B
Theo

Week beginning
5 October 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Plan the week's meals*	*Theo*	20	*Thinking and planning*
Mon	*Cook dinner*	*Marcus*	45	*Asked for*
Tue	*Book the boiler service*	*Theo*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Dishes*	*Marcus*	20	*Asked for*
Wed	*Laundry, wash to put away*	*Theo*	60	*Noticed and handled*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Thu	*Remember Marcus's mum's birthday card*	*Theo*	*10*	*Thinking and planning*
Fri	*Bins and recycling out*	*Marcus*	*10*	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Big food shop*	*Both*	*70*	*Asked for*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Marcus
110 minutes (44%), of which 10 noticed and handled without being asked

Theo
140 minutes (56%), of which 105 noticed and handled without being asked (30 of them thinking and planning)

Workload balance score
0.88. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Theo did 91% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented.

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

05

Each of you writes only your own side.

Nobody fills in anything for the other person. You each note what you did, then read the two lists together. That keeps it fair and keeps it kind. Each of you also adds the context only you have, like what the week was like, so you both understand rather than judge.

For example: Kai, Dani and Sol are three partners sharing a home. Each writes only their own list. Reading them together, Sol learns Kai has been calling the landlord every month.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I've written my side. Would you like to write yours, in your own words, when you're ready?"

> TRY THIS:
> Add one line of context to your own list, like "long week at work" or "the kids were ill." It helps the other person understand, not judge.

06

The borrowed words are there to take the blame away.

The book uses a few terms from accounting and science because they describe what's happening without saying whose fault it is. Each one is explained in plain words, and you never need them to use anything here.

For example: Two brothers share their mum's care. Instead of "you never help," one says, "There's some unseen work here we haven't looked at." That's much easier to hear.

New together? If words like "ledger" or "debt" feel heavy a few months in, use your own. "Our list" and "the stuff nobody sees" work just as well. The idea stays the same: two people looking at one honest picture, kindly, so nobody has to guess.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Let's look at how it's set up, not at each other."

TRY THIS:

Swap one blaming phrase you use, like “you never,” for a plain one, like “this job keeps landing on me.”

07

One small step at a time.

Each chapter adds one idea and one tool. One week of notes is enough to start. Later come a 90-second daily check-in about how much you were carrying today, a weekly catch-up and a monthly look-back. If you use the monthly look-back later, a few lines a week is all it needs.

For example: A nurse on nights and a partner on days hardly see each other awake. They start with one week of notes on the fridge. No changes yet.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

“Could we just try one week of notes and see what we notice? We don’t have to change anything yet.”

TRY THIS:

Pick a start day this week and set one reminder on your phone. That’s the whole first step.

08

It can help in many kinds of shared life.

Partners, family, roommates, co-parents and coworkers all share unseen work. The examples often use a couple at home, but the ideas fit anyone who shares a load.

For example: A foster carer tracks family visits, social worker calls and school meetings. A teenager in the home quietly cooks for the younger ones twice a week. Both count.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

“Whatever we are to each other, we share some work. Could we look at it together?”

TRY THIS:

Name one shared load in your life that isn't a couple: a family group chat, a shared flat, a team at work.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't make anyone see the unseen work, and you can't write their side of the ledger. You can write your own side honestly, say it once, kindly, and then match what you take on to what comes back. If you keep carrying more than your share with nothing in return, stepping back toward your share isn't a punishment. It protects the energy you need to stay kind. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

FRIDAY, AFTER WORK

"You didn't have to do all that," they say, and they mean it kindly. You think: someone did. The list only ever lived in your head, so to them it looked like it took care of itself.

The mental load: what the research says

Many people call the thinking side of home life the **mental load**: the noticing and planning that come before a job gets done, and the checking after. Knowing the baby needs the next size of clothes. Remembering the form, the jab, the party present. It's real work, even when it doesn't look like any.

Studies of couples find some patterns, *on average*. In couples of a man and a woman, women tend to do more of the noticing and checking (Allison Daminger, 2019). After a first baby, a gap often opens: in one study of working couples, mothers took on most of the new childcare while keeping their paid hours (Jill Yavorsky and colleagues, 2015). Arlie Hochschild called the home work that starts after paid work ends "the second shift."

There is a fair point on the other side too. Sometimes the parent who knows how things are done holds on to that, without meaning to. Researchers call it *gatekeeping*. When a parent openly invites the other in, and lets them do it

their own way, the other parent tends to do more of the care (Sarah Allen and Alan Hawkins, 1999; Sarah Schoppe-Sullivan and colleagues, 2008).

These are averages across many homes, not a verdict on yours. In your home it may be the other way round, or already even, or shared between two men or two women. That's why the book asks you to look at your own week on paper, instead of guessing.

For example (made up): Hollie and Gareth have a toddler and a baby, and Gareth works shifts. Their week's minutes come out nearly even. But Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked anyone to do. Their week is in Chapter II (page 61).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "You do lots of the doing. It's the remembering I'd love you to take some of: whole jobs, start to finish." Or, the other way round: "Show me once how you like it done, then let me do it my way."

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Notice everything you carry, including the thinking and feeling work you have never counted. Notice, too, the work others do that you may have missed.
- **Between you and others:** Put both lists on one shared, fair page, so nobody has to argue about whose work "counts." Jobs nobody claims tend to drift to whoever notices first, and a specific thank-you helps keep things steady.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I want to see what you carry, too, not just what I carry." "Could we put both our weeks on one page?"

On your own: your own unseen work

You don't need anyone else to start seeing the unseen. For one week, notice the jobs only you remember: the appointments, the restocking, the

smoothing-over. Write them down for yourself, not as a bill.

- Count it, don't charge it. The point is to see your real load, so you can plan your energy.
- Notice which jobs are yours by choice and which just landed on you.
- Pick one job you could hand back, drop or do less often, and say so kindly.

For example: Dee, divorced, has the children every other week. On paper, she sees she still buys presents for both sides of the family. She hands his side back, kindly, in one message.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I've noticed I've been doing this for both of us. From next month, could you take it on?" Or, to yourself: "That was real work, even if nobody saw it."

TRY THIS:

Circle one job on your list that is yours by choice. Enjoy it. Then circle one that just landed on you, and decide what you'll do about it. More for people living alone or after a breakup: On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:

Step 1: check your battery (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 6: kind ways to say no · Part One: your circle of control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth) · The whole book on sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-share-the-load)

The fields behind this chapter

Christian, who wrote this book, worked as a government auditor and is a polymath: someone who studied thirteen fields deeply (psychology, philosophy, behavioural science, neurobiology, economics, business, finance, holistic therapies, aromatherapy, the art of debating, politics, music and the healing power of laughter). This chapter grows from 5 of them:

- **Finance** (See the whole load): The idea of an unbilled hour: work that was done and logged, but never invoiced, so the client never sees it.
- **Economics** (See the whole load): Attention is limited. Every reminder you hold in your head takes up some of it.
- **Psychology** (See the whole load): We remember our own effort best.
- **Philosophy** (See the whole load): Telling what we know from how things look. In Plato's Cave, people mistake shadows for the real thing.
- **Business** (Notice the quiet incentives): Work that belongs to everyone belongs to no one, and it lands on whoever notices first.

Two fields, one idea: Finance + Psychology. In double-entry bookkeeping, every amount is recorded in two places, and the two must agree. And we each remember our own effort best. Put together: each person keeps their own record, and the two records are read side by side.

Where this comes from: the polymath way

This book is built on a polymath's habit: looking at very different fields and noticing that the same few roots keep turning up. Those roots are balance, signal and noise, feedback loops, limited capacity, ownership, quiet incentives, and state and setting. A ledger, a nervous system and a conversation look nothing alike, yet each one has a limit, each one can lose a message in the noise, and each one stays steady only when what goes out is matched by what comes back.

Christian saw those roots across thirteen fields. The four newest to the list are the art of debating, politics, music and the healing power of laughter. They shape the gentler parts of the book: how to disagree without a fight, how a small group decides fairly, how tone and tempo change what lands, and how a shared laugh can repair a hard moment.

Read the polymath way · See how every field connects to every other

In real life

- **Partners:** One of you keeps track of birthdays, presents and thank-you notes for both families. The other has never had to think about it.
- **Family:** One grown-up child handles a parent's appointments and prescription refills each week. The others see a parent who is "doing fine."
- **Roommates:** One roommate always buys the toilet paper and the dish soap. Nobody asked them to. It just keeps happening.
- **Coworkers:** One person books the meetings, takes the notes and follows up afterward. It isn't in anyone's job description.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I didn't know you did that. Thank you." "Can we look at who does the remembering, not just the doing?"

More kinds of shared life

Unseen work turns up wherever people share something:

- **Two mums:** one holds the baby's dates and forms in her head; the other does lots of hands-on care.
- **More than two partners:** a job nobody owns lands on whoever notices first. More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two)
- **Friends:** one friend always makes the plans and sends the "how are you?" Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Teens:** walking the dog and minding a sister feels like a lot to them, and like "helping a bit" to adults. For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Grandparents and grown-up children:** childcare comes with planning work, too. Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children)
- **Adult siblings:** one sorts a late parent's paperwork for months. Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- **Co-parents and carers:** packing the right kit for two homes; meetings and reports on top of care. Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/

co-parenting) · Foster and kinship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)

- **Housemates, coworkers and business partners:** one person always notices the bathroom, or chases the invoices. Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- **Illness, different hours, distance, two faiths:** the one at home more, or the one who is well, becomes the default; the ill partner manages unseen pain and energy. When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours) · Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance) · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths)

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't need it to be even. I need it to be seen."

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) · How it fits your relationships (spreadloveandacceptance.com/relationships).

Your situation, in this part of the book

Some situations get their own section in Part Two:

- **Faith, culture, elders and in-laws:** Chapter I (page 41)
- **Small children or a new baby:** Chapter II (page 61)
- **Two homes after a split, and step-parents:** Chapter III (page 82)
- **Money between you:** Chapter IV (page 102)
- **A couple and a housemate:** Chapter IV (page 103)
- **New together, or about to move in:** Chapter V (page 120)
- **Grandparents raising a grandchild:** Chapter V (page 121)

Common mix-ups

- **"If it mattered, they would have asked for help."** Unseen work is often hidden from the person doing it, too, until it's written down.
- **"Writing it down means I'm angry."** It means you want you both to see the same picture.
- **"It has to be exactly 50/50."** The goal is a split you can both see and both agree to, not a perfect half.
- **"Mental work doesn't count, only chores do."** Remembering, planning and checking take real time and energy. Put them on the list.
- **"We should start by going over the last ten years."** Start with one ordinary week. You can thank someone for the past without trying to settle it.
- **"The one doing less doesn't care."** Usually they just can't see it yet. Nobody here is the villain. Once you've both seen it, what you do next is a choice you make together.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I don't think either of us is the bad guy here. We just haven't seen the same picture yet."

TRY THIS:

Each of you, on your own, list the things you did this week that nobody saw. Then swap lists.

Next, read the other list slowly and say one thing on it you hadn't noticed before.

Then pick one item from their list and say thank you for it, in a specific way.

If writing things down isn't your style, a ten-minute talk over a cup of coffee with the same questions works too.

Keep it light. This is a first look, not a verdict. The fixing comes later in the book.

Limits and cautions

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A list should never be demanded, checked over your shoulder, or used to keep track of where you go or what you spend. If that is happening, it isn't a ledger. It's control, and it's not your fault. Signs to look out for. If you are a counsellor or group leader using this book with others, see For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors).

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Running a home takes unseen work:** the noticing, remembering and planning that many people call the mental load.
- ✓ **The other person usually just hasn't seen it.** This work hides by nature. It isn't a sign that they don't care.
- ✓ **Each of you writes only your own side** of one ordinary week, and you read the two lists together.
- ✓ **The list is for seeing, not for billing.** Thank each other for the past, and plan next week.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working? page 47
Putting the unseen work into numbers you both trust

Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other read online
Why each person sees their own work first

Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well read online
Care work and how not to burn out

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words read online
What fair means to you before you talk

PUT IT TO USE



Six-week program, week 1: see the work that's already happening
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



Who did what
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01

I

PART TWO · CHAPTER I

Why we get out of tune: communication at home

Why two kind, reasonable people can end up in a tangle neither of them started, and how to get back in step.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. The tangle often isn't about the words
2. Nearly in step is the noisy part
3. Three things knock you out of tune
4. Stress changes your station
5. Nobody has to be wrong
6. Get back in tune before you carry on
7. Go back in with a clear sentence
8. Small daily check-ins keep you in tune
9. Faith, culture and family voices
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: your side of the tuning
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. In real life
14. More kinds of shared life
15. Common mix-ups

IN SHORT:

- **A clash often isn't about the words.** Pace, tone and urgency can be out of step even when both of you mean well.
- **Nobody has to be wrong.** Name it ("we're out of tune"), pause with a time to come back, and slow down.
- **Go back in with one clear sentence:** a fact, a feeling and an ask.
- **A 90-second daily check-in** keeps small drifts small.

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

"I said I'd do it." "I know, I'm just asking when." Four sentences later, nobody is talking about the bins any more, and neither of you can point to the moment it turned.

01

The tangle often isn't about the words.

Two people can each say something reasonable and still clash, because the tone underneath doesn't match. It's like two radios slightly out of tune: together they make a crackle that neither one was making alone.

For example: Two housemates. "Is anyone using the oven tonight?" "Why, did I leave a mess?" A plain question was heard as a complaint.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think the words were fine. Something in how we said them got crossed."

TRY THIS:

After your next small clash, ask yourself: was it the words, or the way they came out?

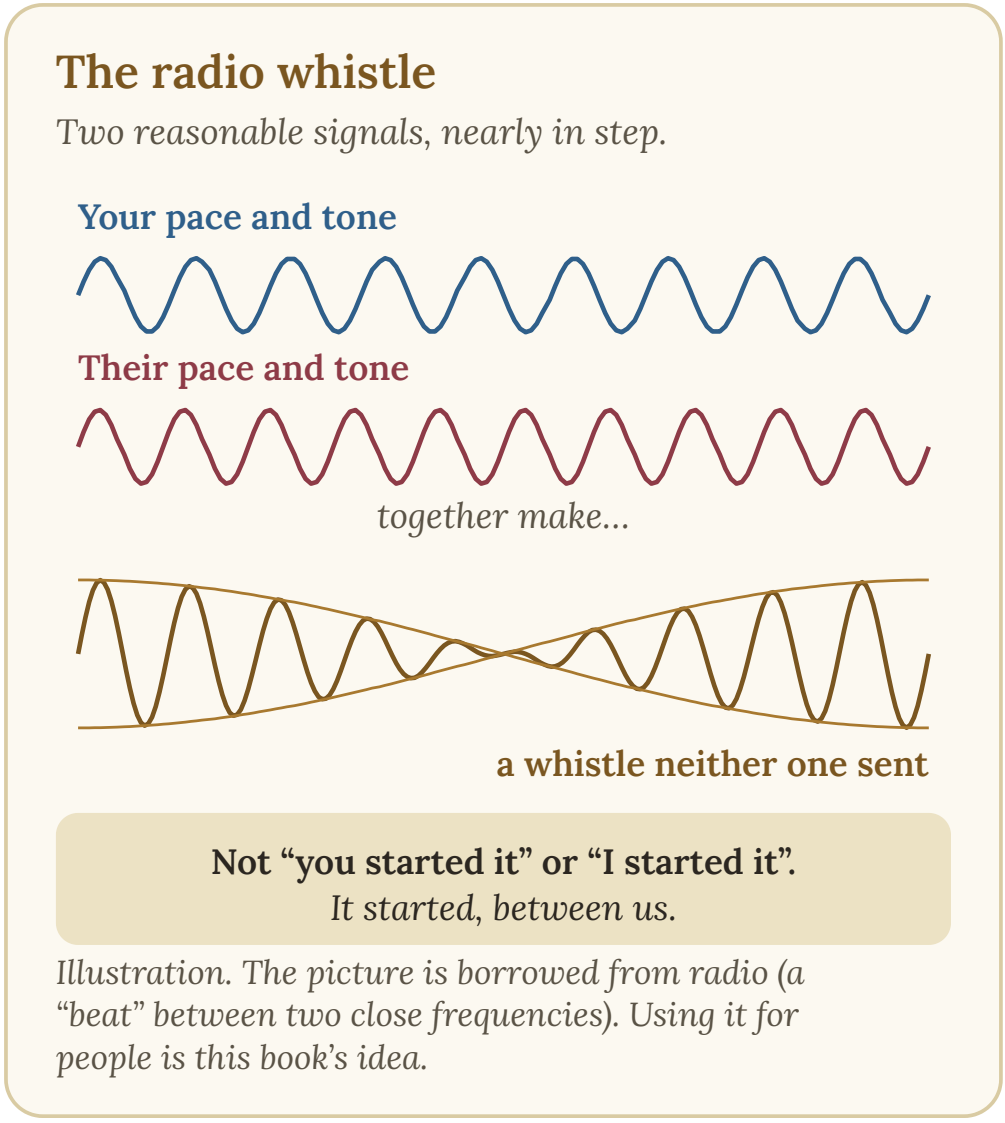


FIGURE 5 The radio whistle. Two reasonable signals, nearly in step, can make a clash that neither person started: it started between you.

02

Nearly in step is the noisy part.

Radios on very different stations don’t whistle at each other. The whistle comes when they are close but not quite matched. People who know each other well can still clash. Research suggests we check our meaning less with people we’re close to, because we assume they already understand us.

For example: Two sisters who talk every day clash over holiday plans far more than they ever do with cousins they see once a year. Being close means more overlap.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I think I assumed you knew what I meant. Let me say it more clearly."

> TRY THIS:
> With someone close, check one meaning today: "Just so I've got it right, you mean...?"

03

Three things knock you out of tune.

How fast you're talking. The tone, when a simple update is heard as a complaint. And how urgent it feels: "when you get a chance" can mean tonight to one person and next week to the other.

For example: A business partner texts "Need to talk" between two meetings. The other partner reads it as a crisis and can't sleep. It was about a printer. A text loses most of the tone, so urgency is easy to misread.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "By when would be good?" "Is this an update, or a worry?"

> TRY THIS:
> Add a time to your next request. Not "at some point," but "by Friday."

04

Stress changes your station.

When you're tense, you may talk faster and be more likely to hear a pause as a snub. When you're tired and flat, your replies get slower and shorter. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, helps you guess which one you're in. It's a best guess, not a reading.

For example: A dad gets home from a night shift and answers his teenager with one word. The teen hears "he doesn't care." He is just running on empty.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm running low right now. It's not about you. Can we talk after I've slept?"

TRY THIS:

Before a tricky talk, name your state to yourself: calm, revved up or running on empty.

05

Nobody has to be wrong.

Two radios that both work fine will still crackle if they're slightly off. Arguing about whose fault the static is won't clear it. Retuning (getting back in step) will.

For example: A grandmother tells her grown-up son, "You look tired." She means care. He hears "you can't cope." Neither of them is wrong about what they meant or heard.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I don't think either of us meant it that way. Can we try that again?"

TRY THIS:

In your next clash, say "we" instead of "you": "We got crossed there."

06

Get back in tune before you carry on.

Say it out loud: "I think we're out of sync." Check how tense you feel. Either of you can call a pause, and the person who paused names a time to come back. Gently slow down, with shorter turns and more pauses. Only then go back to the actual topic.

For example: Two dorm roommates agree on a pause word, "static," on a calm day. Mid-argument about noise, one says it. They stop, and come back at 9pm as agreed.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I need ten minutes. I'll come back at half past."

TRY THIS:

Agree a pause word with someone today, while you are both calm.

Retuning, step by step

Before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.

1. **Name the mismatch, without blame**
   "I think we're on different wavelengths."
2. **Check your own state**
   Revved up or running on empty? Pause, and name a time to come back.
3. **Slow the pace on purpose**
   Shorter turns, more pauses, a lower voice.
4. **Then go back to the topic**
   It still matters. Now you can both hear it.

This book's four steps. Anyone can call a pause, and nobody should be blocked from leaving the room.

FIGURE 6 Retuning, step by step, before you carry on with a talk that has started to whistle.

07

Go back in with a clear sentence.

When you return to the topic, say the fact, how you feel, and what you'd like. "The bins go out early on Wednesday morning. I get anxious when they're late. Could you put them out tonight?"

For example: A co-parent texts: "The swim kit wasn't in the bag. I felt stressed at drop-off. Could you pack it on Sunday nights?" A fact, a feeling, an ask.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "The fact is… I feel… Could we…?"

> TRY THIS:
> Write one fact, feeling and ask sentence about something small, before you need it.

08

Small daily check-ins keep you in tune.

A short chat each day, like the 90-second daily check-in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in), can make tiny corrections before small things drift into a big argument. Habit research suggests small routines at a regular time are easier to keep than big ones done rarely. The quiet, easy stretches are the ones that drift most, so keep it going even when nothing seems wrong (see Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency)).

For example: A long-distance couple in two time zones send one 90-second voice note each morning. It's tiny, but it keeps them in step.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Today I was carrying quite a lot. One thing I liked today was…"

> TRY THIS:
> Pick a time and a cue, like right after dinner, and try the check-in for three days.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

The 90-second daily check-in

Priya and Dev, a couple on different shifts

The 90-second daily check-in

Person A
Priya

Person B
Dev

Week beginning
5 October 2026

Each day

Day	Person	Load	One thing I appreciated today	One small thing that didn't feel great	One thing that would help tomorrow
Mon	Priya	High	You left soup in the fridge before my night shift	Woke up to the washing still in the machine	A text when you're leaving work
Mon	Dev	Medium	Your note on the kettle		Bins out before I go at six
Tue	Priya	High	You kept the house quiet till noon		Ten minutes together at the shift change
Tue	Dev	Low	You booked the car in	Missed you at dinner again	
Wed	Priya	Medium	Breakfast together at 8		Early night
Wed	Dev	Medium	You remembered my mum's call		

LOAD THIS WEEK

Priya
2 high, 1 medium, 0 low

Dev
0 high, 2 medium, 1 low

The weekly catch-up

Sore spot that keeps coming up	Times this week	Move to
Washing left in the machine	2	*One owner per job*
Missing each other at dinner	2	*Keep watching*

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. One sentence each, then just listen: no debating, no solving.

Fill in your own: The 90-second daily check-in
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13)

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control what you send, whether you check how it landed, and whether you step out to retune. You don't control how it's heard or how fast the other person settles. Matching energy here means matching care and effort, never volume: if someone gets louder, you don't have to follow. Stay at your level, and give the conversation the energy it gives back. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SATURDAY, 10AM

"We should clear out the spare room at some point." One of you meant this month. The other heard today and has already cancelled their plans in their head. By lunchtime you're both upset about a room nobody has touched.

Faith, culture and family voices

For many couples, faith is where they turn first. If you share a faith, it can be one of your strongest tools for staying in tune.

- **A shared rhythm:** praying together, or a quiet moment after worship, can be your daily check-in.
- **A pause with a purpose:** some couples pray, each on their own, before they come back to a hard talk. The pause still has a time to come back.
- **Your community:** a pastor, imam, rabbi, priest or trusted elder can be a good first person to talk to. Many can also suggest a trained counsellor who shares your faith.

For example (made up): Emeka and Ngozi, married 26 years, do their monthly look-back on a Sunday after church, over lunch. When a talk gets heated, either of them can say, "Let's pray on it and come back at eight." And they do.

Culture shapes how you talk, too. In many families, respect for elders decides who can speak plainly to whom. One habit helps: each of you speaks to your own parents and relatives, after you've agreed the message together.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Can we pray about this and talk again tonight?" "Mum, we love you, and we've thought about it carefully. This year we'll visit in August, not at Easter."

From two faiths or cultures? See Two faiths or cultures, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Know your own pace, your usual tone and what "soon" means to you. Notice when stress speeds you up or slows you down.
- **Between you and others:** When a clash starts, treat it as a tuning problem, not a moral failing. Retune together, then translate what you meant into words the other person can hear.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think this is a tuning problem, not a you problem." "What did you hear me say? I want to check it came out right."

On your own: your side of the tuning

Getting out of tune takes two, but retuning can start with one. You can learn your own pace, tone and urgency, so you notice when you're the one running fast or slow.

- Learn your early signs of drifting: a tight chest, a clipped reply, wanting to win.
- Learn how you take words in best, and say it once: "I hear things better in writing."
- When you drift, step out, settle and come back. You don't need anyone's permission to retune yourself.

For example: Theo lives alone and notices his texts to friends come out short when he's tired. Now he waits until morning to answer anything that matters.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm tired, so I might sound shorter than I mean. Can I reply properly tomorrow?"

TRY THIS:

For one day, notice the first sign in your body that you're drifting. Write it down. More for people on their own: On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:

Step 2: get to know your wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 4: plan what settles you · Part One: who you are today · The whole book on talking it through (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-talk-it-through)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 5 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface (page 12) or the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about)):

- **Psychology** (Tune how you send and receive): The gap between intent and impact: why a clear, kind sentence can still land as an attack, once pace, tone or urgency slips.
- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): How stress changes your frequency, and how you sound and hear.
- **Philosophy** (Fix the setup, not the person): Nobody has to be wrong. Zhuangzi's Empty Boat: much of the time, the bump was no one's plan.
- **Behavioural science** (Tune how you send and receive): Small and often. A small routine at a regular time is easier to keep.
- **Holistic therapies** (Read your state first): Body first, argument second. Settle your own state before you go back to the talk.

Two fields, one idea: Neurobiology + Psychology. A tired body changes how words sound and how they're heard. So the same sentence can be fine on Saturday and a fight on Tuesday. Check your state, then say it.

In real life

- **Partners:** "Did you pay the gas bill?" is meant as a reminder. After a long day, it lands as "you forgot again."
- **Family:** A parent asks, "Are you coming on Sunday?" They mean it as a simple question. Their grown-up child hears guilt.
- **Roommates:** A message says, "Can we talk about the kitchen?" One roommate meant a quick chat. The other spends all afternoon worrying.
- **Coworkers:** "Quick question" arrives at 5:55pm. The sender meant tomorrow is fine. The reader thinks it's urgent and stays late.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I meant that as a question, not a complaint. Sorry it came out sharp."

More kinds of shared life

Getting out of tune happens wherever people talk often:

- **Two dads:** "Did you call the school?" is a reminder to one and a test to the other.
- **Three partners:** two speak fast and one slowly, so the slow one gets talked over. More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two)
- **Friends:** a one-word reply after a long message reads as cold, when they were just busy. Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends)
- **Gaming and phones:** "Five more minutes" means five to one person and a match to the other. Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together)
- **Teens and parents:** a parent's worry comes out fast and sounds like anger. For teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens)
- **Adult siblings:** after years apart, an old nickname lands like an old fight. Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- **Foster and kinship carers:** a child who has been hurt may hear a raised voice as danger, even when it isn't. Foster and kinship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship)
- **Different hours, illness, two faiths:** a tired shift worker, a partner in pain, or two family styles of speaking can all shift the tune. Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours) · When one is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Two faiths

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship).

Common mix-ups

- **"Retuning means giving in."** It doesn't. You still come back to the topic. You just come back when you can hear each other.
- **"If we're out of sync, one of us must be wrong."** Two fair points in two different tones can still clash.
- **"Slowing down means I don't care."** Slowing down is how you show you want to get it right.
- **"A pause means the topic is dropped."** A pause always comes with a time to come back.
- **"We should push through while we're on the subject."** Pushing on through static usually makes more static.

TRY THIS:

Next time a conversation starts to go wrong, pause and say so kindly, instead of pushing through.

Before then, agree on a shared phrase, like "I think we're out of tune." That way it feels like a signal, not a criticism.

For one week, each of you notes one moment you felt out of step. At the end, compare: was it mostly pace, tone or urgency?

When someone says "when you get a chance," kindly ask, "By when would be good?"

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think we're out of tune. Can we slow down?" "I want to get this right, so I'm going to go slower."

A limit to keep in mind: These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking things through ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When

someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A pause is for both of you. If one person is never allowed to pause, or a "pause" is used to punish with days of silence, that isn't retuning. Signs to look out for.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **A clash often isn't about the words.** Pace, tone and urgency can be out of step even when both of you mean well.
- ✓ **Nobody has to be wrong.** Name it ("we're out of tune"), pause with a time to come back, and slow down.
- ✓ **Go back in with one clear sentence:** a fact, a feeling and an ask.
- ✓ **A 90-second daily check-in** keeps small drifts small.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works read online
How meaning, tone and listening work

Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system read online
Why stress speeds people up or shuts them down

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words read online
How you like to be spoken to

Part Three · Chapter 9 · Minds that work differently read online
When pace and tone are a wiring difference

PUT IT TO USE



Six-week program, week 1
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



The 90-second daily check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-13-daily-check-in

II

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

Is the split working? A fair look at chores at home

One gentle question: can the way you share the work keep going, or is one of you quietly running on empty?

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Look at the month, not last night
2. Three things go in
3. Balance: how the hours split
4. Ownership: does each job have a name?
5. Stress: how full each stress tank is
6. One number comes out, from 0 to 1
7. Start with the biggest shortfall
8. It judges the setup, never a person
9. Words this chapter uses
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: is your own load working?
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. In real life
14. Common mix-ups
15. Small children and a new baby
16. If only one of you wants to try this
17. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **Look at the month, not last night.** Use what you both wrote down, not memory.
- **Three things go in:** balance (how the hours split), ownership (does each job have a name?) and stress (how full each tank is).
- **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- **It judges the setup, never a person.** It's where a talk starts, not how one ends.

ANY GIVEN WEEK

One of you is quietly doing eleven small things a day that the other has never had to think about. When the other one says it feels even, they mean it. From inside each person's own week, it does.

01

Look at the month, not last night.

When people ask "Is this working?", the answer usually comes from whatever happened most recently. This chapter asks a calmer question, using what you both wrote down. Re-ask it every few months, even when things seem fine, because a split that worked once can quietly go stale.

For example: Two housemates had one awful week of dishes. The whole month showed three fine weeks and one exam week.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can we look at the whole month before we decide anything?"

TRY THIS:

Put a short check in your calendar for about a month from now.

02

Three things go in.

How evenly the hours are shared. Whether every regular job has a clear owner (the job list, One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job)). And how stressed each of you already is from everything else going on.

A **workpaper** is one of the site's free fill-in worksheets. You don't need any of them to start. Rough notes on paper work too.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Let's each bring our own numbers, so neither of us has to guess."

TRY THIS:

Open the three worksheets once, just to see what they ask.

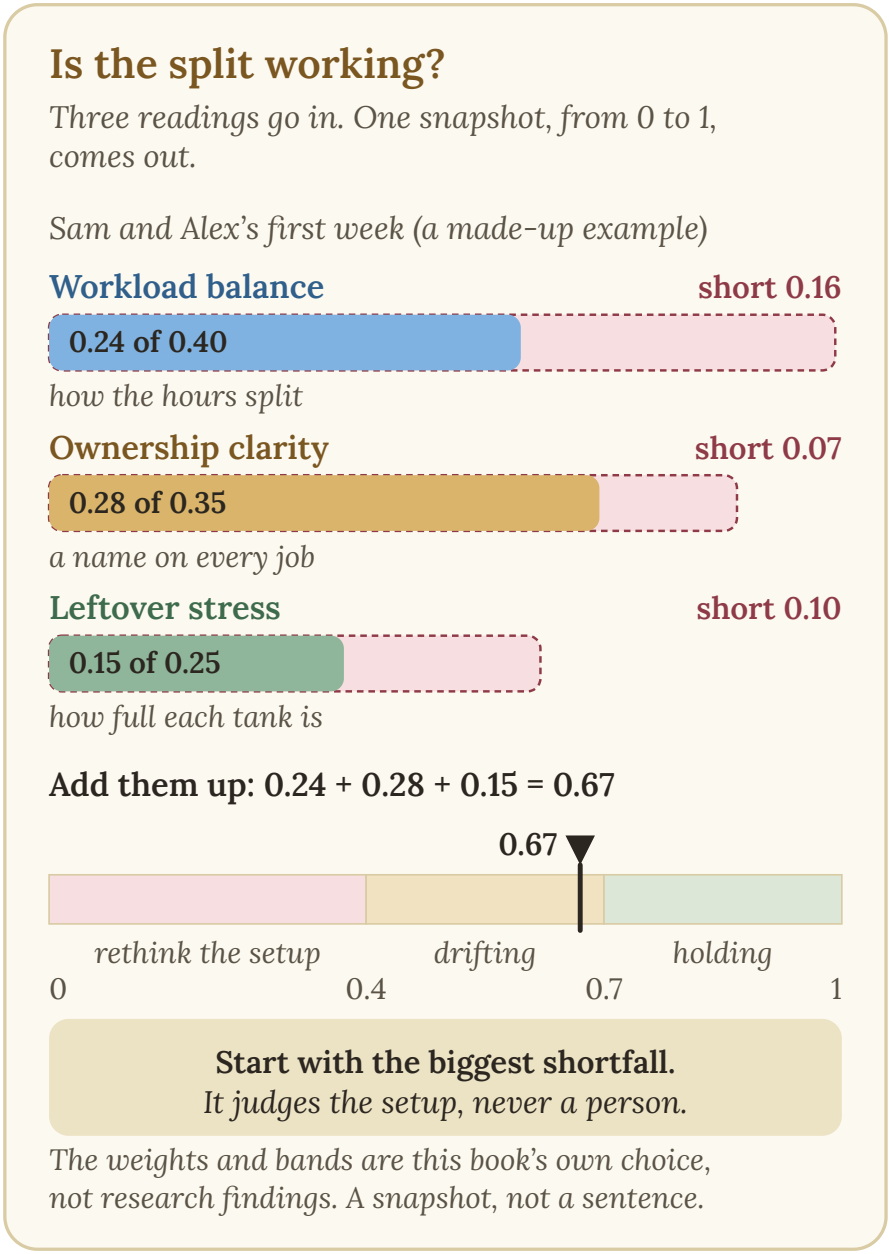


FIGURE 7 Is the split working? Three readings go in and one snapshot comes out. Start with the biggest shortfall. It judges the setup, never a person.

03

Balance: how the hours split.

From your week-long logs, work out each person's share of the hours. An even split scores 1. One person doing everything scores 0. It doesn't matter which person is doing more. If you agreed an uneven split that suits you (say, one of you works longer hours outside the home), compare against that split instead.

For example: Three partners log 30 hours of home jobs: 15, 9 and 6. An even share is 10 each.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'm not keeping score of you. I just want us both to see the hours."

TRY THIS:
Log one week each, and include the small jobs that take under ten minutes.

Three or more of you? Compare each person's share with an even share (100 ÷ number of people), or with a split you agreed. The Lemonade Stand (spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand), a free page where each person lists their hours, does the arithmetic.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

The Lemonade Stand: quick look
Wren, Josh and Mei, housemates (Wren's view)

Quick look: who does what at home

Tap who mostly does each job. The picture builds as you go, the thinking work too.

Your name	Their name
Wren	*Josh*
Person 3	
Mei	

Job	Who mostly does it
Dishes	*Shared*
Laundry	*Shared*
Cleaning the bathroom	*Josh*
Cooking dinner	*Mei*
Grocery shopping	*Wren*
Paying bills	*Wren*
Noticing what's running low	*Wren*
Planning the week	*Mei*
Remembering dates and appointments	*Wren*

HOW IT LOOKS

Here's how it looks from your side, 9 jobs so far.

Everyday jobs: mostly shared. 6 jobs: Wren 2 · Josh 1 · Mei 1 · Shared 2.

Planning and remembering: mostly Wren. 3 jobs: Wren 2 · Mei 1.

The thinking work is easy to miss, because nobody sees it happen. Saying it out loud is a good start.

Does this match how it feels to the three of you?

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Pets and booking appointments were taken off the list: they don't happen in this house.

Fill in your own: The Lemonade Stand quick look
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

04

Ownership: does each job have a name?

Each job gets two names: the owner, who does the job start to finish, and a backstop, who notices if it slipped and gently checks in (never a supervisor). It can be the same person, though a second name gives the job a gentle check. Count the jobs that have an owner, then divide by all the jobs on the

list. (The backstop is a good habit on top, but the count only needs the owner.) Leave jobs nobody owns on the list. They are the ones that matter most.

A *decision* you make together, like which school, can be marked "Both (decide together)". It counts as owned, because a decision needs both voices. A *job* that needs doing gets one name.

For example: Two sisters care for their dad. Nobody owned his prescription, so each thought the other had ordered it.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Can we put a name next to this one, so it doesn't fall between us?"

> TRY THIS:
> Find one job with no name, and give it an owner and a backstop today.

05

Stress: how full each stress tank is.

Each of you rates how full your own stress tank is with How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying). A higher score means more stress. Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 up to 0.60 is moderate, and 0.60 or more is high. The score uses the average of your scores. But if either of you is at 0.60 or more, talk about that first, even when the score looks fine. A setup that only works when you're both well rested isn't one that can last, so more stress lowers the result.

For example: A grandmother raising two grandchildren scores 0.70. Her son, who helps at weekends, scores 0.35. Her 0.70 is the headline.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "My tank is high this week. Can we plan around that, not around the average?"

TRY THIS:

Each of you scores your own tank on the same day, before looking at the other's.

06

One number comes out, from 0 to 1.

0.70 or above: *working well*, the setup is holding. From 0.40 up to 0.70: *needs a look*, something is drifting, often who owns what. Below 0.40: *needs a rethink, together*. (The result is called the setup score. It looks like a probability, but it isn't one. It's a simple weighted sum.)

A **weighted sum** means each part counts for a set share: the hours count most, then the owners, then stress.

For example: Two friends who run a café score 0.55. Nothing is broken, but something is drifting.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"This number is about our setup, not about us."

TRY THIS:

Write the date next to your number, so you can compare next month.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

Is the setup working for everyone?
Rosemary and Ken, retired, married 41 years

Is the setup working for everyone?

Person 1 (optional)
Rosemary

Person 2 (optional)
Ken

1. How the hours split

From Who did what or the Lemonade Stand: each person's total hours for the week.

Rosemary, hours	Ken, hours
14	10

2. Does each job have a name?

From One owner per job.

Jobs on the list	Jobs with an owner
12	9

3. How much each person is carrying

Each person's own score from How much are you carrying? Everyone fills in their own.

Rosemary, load (0 to 1)	Ken, load (0 to 1)
0.45	0.30

HOW THE SETUP IS WORKING

Working well

0.75 of 1. The setup is carrying its own weight.

Next: nothing in the setup needs changing this week. Keep the same rhythm of check-ins.

If you want to nudge it higher one day (optional, not urgent): hand about 2 hours a week from Rosemary to Ken, and balance would go from 0.83 to 1.00. Give one more job an owner (the person who does it and sees it through), and ownership would go from 0.75 to 0.83.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. It scores the setup, never a person, and never the relationship as a whole.

Fill in your own: Is the setup working for everyone?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/calculators/is-the-setup-working-quick)

07

Start with the biggest shortfall.

The single number matters less than which of the three parts pulled it down most. In the middle band that is often ownership, which is why the calculator suggests One owner per job first. Once you've both seen it, what you do next is a choice you make together.

The **shortfall** is how far one part fell below the most it could add.

For example: Separated parents score 0.62. Their biggest gap: nobody owns school forms. They fix only that.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Which part pulled the number down most? Let's start there."

TRY THIS:
Choose one small change, not five.

08

It judges the setup, never a person.

The number isn't a verdict on who's better or whether the relationship works. It's where a conversation starts, never how one ends. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about the split ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

For example: One partner sees 0.35: "So I'm the problem." The other: "No. The bathroom has no owner, and you work nights."

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Whatever this shows, I'm on your side."

TRY THIS:

Before you start, agree that either of you can say "pause" and come back later.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. The score describes the setup you share, but your levers are your own: your jobs, your hours and what you agree to take on. You can propose a fix; you can't make the other person accept it. If the balance stays one-sided, step your load back toward your share on purpose, and say so kindly. Matching effort with effort protects your stress tank, and your tank is part of the score too. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

SUNDAY EVENING

Two week-long logs and two cups of tea. One list has 31 rows. The other has 18. Nobody says anything for a moment. Then one of you says, "I honestly didn't know about half of these."

Words this chapter uses

- **Log:** a simple list of the jobs you did this week and roughly how long each took.
- **Owner:** the person who does a job from start to finish, including remembering it.
- **Backstop:** the person who notices if a job slipped and gently checks in. A helper, never a boss.
- **Stress tank:** how much stress you are already carrying from the rest of life.
- **Setup:** the way you share the work right now. It can always be changed.
- **Setup score:** one number from 0 to 1 that sums up the three readings. It describes the setup, never a person.

Invisible jobs count too. Planning meals, remembering birthdays, booking the vet and noticing the soap is running low are all work, even though nobody sees them happen. Put them in your log.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'd like to add the thinking jobs to our list, like remembering and planning. They take time too."

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** See your own share honestly, from what you wrote down rather than from memory. See the way you share work as a setup you can redesign, not a flaw in you.
- **Between you and others:** Put both people's numbers on one page, and read the result as a note about the setup, never a verdict on a person. Clear owners leave less room for blame.

On your own: is your own load working?

This chapter asks whether a shared setup can last. You can ask the same about your own week: are you spending more energy than comes back in?

- Add up what you carry: jobs, people and worries.
- Set it beside what refills you: rest, help, and people who give back.
- If it runs in the red, change your side: drop, delay, ask or say no kindly. A limit is a statement about supply, not about your worth.

For example: After a breakup, Dee has her kids every other week, and fills the quiet weeks with favors for friends. Writing it down showed her she never rests. More in On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I'd love to help, and I can't this week. Can I let you know next week?"

TRY THIS:

Tonight, write three things that drained you this week and one thing that refilled you.

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:

Step 1: check your battery (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 6: kind ways to say no · Part One: matching energy (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth) · The whole book on sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-share-the-load)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 6 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface or the About page). The first few:

- **Finance** (See the whole load): Like a small shop asking whether it can keep paying its bills, month after month. The chapter reads the setup that way, never as a verdict on the people.
- **Business** (Fix the setup, not the person): Ownership clarity: one owner per job, borrowed from project work, and the maker-and-checker habit from internal controls. Every regular job gets a person who does it and a backstop who notices if it slipped.
- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): Leftover stress: a quick self-rating of the stress you're already carrying. It borrows the idea that stress builds up in the body, but it doesn't measure your body.
- **Economics** (See the whole load): Limited capacity and the safety margin.

Two fields, one idea: Business + Economics. Unowned work falls to whoever notices first, every time. That's what turns a fixable imbalance into a repeating one, so the check counts owners, not just the hours.

In real life

- **Partners:** After a new baby arrives, the hours tip heavily one way without anyone deciding it. The check can show it before resentment builds.

- **Family:** Two siblings share care for a parent. One lives nearby and does most of the visits. Writing down the hours helps them rebalance in other ways, like paperwork and phone calls.
- **Roommates:** Everyone agrees cleaning matters, but nobody owns the bathroom. The ownership score shows the gap straight away.
- **Coworkers:** Two people share one role. The same three questions still work: how the hours split, who owns what, and how stretched each person is.
- **Two dads:** With no old script for who does what, nothing was decided. One of them quietly took on all the school messages.
- **More than two partners:** In a home of three or more, "someone will do it" often means nobody does. Owners matter even more. See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).
- **Foster and kinship carers:** Meetings, forms and contact visits are real work. See Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).
- **Shift workers:** Hours can look even while sleep is not. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).
- **When one of you is ill:** Share by energy, and agree an uneven split on purpose. See When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).
- **Dorm roommates:** A room agreement with names next to jobs settles most of it. See Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think the way we split things worked before, and life changed. Can we look at it again together?"

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

Our room agreement

Kayla and Bea, first-year roommates

Our room agreement

Your name
Kayla

Their name
Bea

Quiet hours
11 pm to 7 am on weeknights, midnight on Fridays and Saturdays. Headphones after that.

Guests (daytime)
Fine with a quick text first. Not during the other one's study or sleep time.

Overnight guests
Up to 2 nights a week, agreed the day before. A guest doesn't stay in the room when their host isn't there.

Cleaning
Kayla: floor and bins, Sunday. Bea: desk area and the fridge, Wednesday. Our own laundry, our own job.

Borrowing
Ask first, every time. Food on the shared shelf is for both of us.

Lights and alarms
Big light off by 11:30 on weeknights; a desk lamp is fine. One alarm, one snooze at most.

How we bring up problems
Text first if that's easier, then talk within a few days, one topic at a time. If we're stuck, we ask our RA to help.

YOUR AGREEMENT, READY TO SEND

Our room agreement (Kayla and Bea), with every line above, ending: "We'll look at it again together in a month."

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. They kept most of the site's starting point and changed two lines.

Fill in your own: Our room agreement (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)

Common mix-ups

- **"A low number means the relationship is failing."** It only means the current setup needs changing. Setups change all the time.
- **"A high number means nobody can complain."** A good score never silences anyone. If something feels wrong, say so.
- **"We can just guess the numbers."** A guessed number is really just a feeling with a decimal point. Use your written logs.
- **"Taking unowned jobs off the list will help."** It raises the number and changes nothing at home.
- **"One of us can fill it in for both."** Each person writes their own log and scores their own stress tank.
- **"Fair means exactly 50/50."** Fair is what you both agree to, with eyes open. An uneven split you chose together can be fair. Chapter IV covers the kinds of fair.
- **"The backstop checks up on the owner."** No. The backstop only notices if something slipped, and asks kindly. It is help, not a check on someone.

Small children and a new baby

Small children bring a flood of new jobs, and most of them are thinking jobs: the nursery bag, the jabs, the party invites, the next size of clothes, the night wakings. That's why the mental load (see the Preface (page 22)) often grows after a baby arrives, usually without anyone deciding it.

- **Log the kid jobs too,** with the thinking time. Nights count.
- **Hand over whole jobs, not tasks:** the clothes and sizes, the nursery bag, the GP and jabs. The new owner does the noticing too, in their own way.
- **Baby on the way?** Write your first job list together before the birth, plan the nights, and agree to look again at six weeks, three months, and before either of you goes back to work.

- **In the first weeks, share by energy, not hours.** Whoever was up in the night gets the rest; the other takes the morning.

For example (made up): Hollie and Gareth have Alfie, 3, and Poppy, 8 months. Gareth is a paramedic on shifts. Their logged minutes come out nearly even, but Hollie did almost three-quarters of the jobs nobody asked for. They don't move minutes. They move one whole job, the children's clothes, to Gareth.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Could you own the nursery bag from now on, including noticing when we're low on nappies? I won't check it."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

Who did what, with small children

Hollie and Gareth, parents of a toddler and a baby; Gareth works shifts

Who did what

Person A
Hollie

Person B
Gareth

Week beginning
12 October 2026

Part A: Who did what, this week

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Mon	*Pack the nursery bag: spare clothes, nappies, named milk*	*Hollie*	10	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Book Poppy's one-year jabs at the GP*	*Hollie*	15	*Noticed and handled*
Tue	*Bath and bedtime, both children*	*Gareth*	45	*Asked for*
Wed	*Reply to a party invite and buy the present*	*Hollie*	25	*Noticed and handled*

Day	Task noticed or done	Who did it	Minutes (rough)	How it came up: asked for, noticed, or thinking time?
Wed	*Sort outgrown clothes and order the next size*	*Hollie*	40	*Noticed and handled*
Thu	*Plan the week's meals around Gareth's nights*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*
Thu	*Cook dinner and batch-cook for the weekend*	*Gareth*	75	*Noticed and handled*
Fri	*Remember the nursery photo money and form*	*Hollie*	10	*Thinking and planning*
Fri	*Night wakings with Poppy*	*Hollie*	60	*Noticed and handled*
Sat	*Swimming lesson with Alfie*	*Gareth*	60	*Asked for*
Sat	*Big food shop and nappies*	*Both*	80	*Asked for*
Sun	*Washing for both children, to put away*	*Hollie*	50	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Fix the stair gate*	*Gareth*	20	*Noticed and handled*
Sun	*Update the family calendar and the childcare rota*	*Hollie*	20	*Thinking and planning*

THIS WEEK'S TOTALS

Hollie
290 minutes (55%), of which 250 noticed and handled without being asked (50 of them thinking and planning)

Gareth
240 minutes (45%), of which 95 noticed and handled without being asked

Workload balance score
0.91. It describes how the logged work was split this week, not anyone in it.

Unasked-for work
Hollie did 72% of the work that was noticed and handled without anyone asking. This is the work that is easiest to miss. Say it out loud, and give the jobs that repeat a named owner.

Part B (optional): Kind ways to say no

Left blank this week.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Gareth worked three night shifts this week, so his rows are fewer; the minutes are close, and the noticing is the part to talk about.

Fill in your own: Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-01)

If only one of you wants to try this

That is common, and you can still start. Log your own week and score your own tank. Then share one small thing you noticed, without asking the other person to agree with your numbers.

For example: A dad noticed he spent five hours a week driving his teenage son around. He just said so, and they agreed a bus pass for two days a week. See Teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I tried writing down my week, just for me. Can I show you one thing I noticed?"

TRY THIS:

Share one finding, not the whole list. Then let it rest for a few days.

If the other person refuses to talk about the split at all, ever, or makes you feel afraid for raising it, that isn't a setup problem. Please read Not safe at home?

More for your situation

Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · Empty nest (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest) · At work (spreadloveandacceptance.com/work) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

TRY THIS:

Each of you logs one week in Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01), first. The number only means something if you each wrote your own.

Next, fill in the job list in One owner per job together, including any jobs nobody owns yet.

Then each of you scores how full your own stress tank is in How much are you carrying? on the same day.

Put the three numbers into the calculator. Look first at the biggest shortfall, pick one small change together, and check again in a month.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Look at the month, not last night.** Use what you both wrote down, not memory.
- ✓ **Three things go in:** balance (how the hours split), ownership (does each job have a name?) and stress (how full each tank is).
- ✓ **One number comes out, from 0 to 1.** Start with whichever part pulled it down most.
- ✓ **It judges the setup, never a person.** It's where a talk starts, not how one ends.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Preface to Part Two · The work nobody sees page 12
The unseen work the check counts

Part Two · Chapter III · Full tanks and different angles page 67
The stress input, explained

Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change read online
Fixing the setup with small, kind changes

Part Three · Chapter 12 · Helping others well read online
When one person carries the care

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 2: give every job one owner
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job

III

PART TWO · CHAPTER III

Full tanks and different angles: stress and perspective

Why some reactions are bigger than what caused them, and why two people can see the same moment so differently.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. A full tank overflows
2. Some stress is left over from earlier
3. Check your stress tank in a minute
4. Three everyday states
5. There are seven angles on the same moment
6. Both views can be true
7. Say it instead of making each other guess
8. A full tank means "later," not "never."
9. Words this chapter uses
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: reading your own tank
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. In real life
14. Common mix-ups
15. Two homes: co-parenting after a split
16. If only one of you wants to try this
17. More for your situation

IN SHORT:

- **A full tank overflows.** Stress left over from earlier makes small things feel big.
- **Check your tank in a minute,** and say the band out loud instead of making others guess.
- **Two people can see one moment from different angles,** and both views can be true.
- **A full tank means "later," not "never":** pause, name a time, and come back.

THURSDAY, 5:15PM

They ask, perfectly pleasantly, whether you remembered to call the dentist. Your reaction is much bigger than the question deserved, and you can hear it happening while it happens.

01

A full tank overflows.

If you're already tired, stretched or stressed from somewhere else, a small question can get a big reaction. That's human. Anything decided in that moment is worth coming back to once you've both calmed down.

For example: A nurse gets home after a night shift. Her housemate asks, "Did you see my message?" She snaps. It wasn't the message. It was twelve hours on her feet.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Sorry. That was bigger than the question. I'm running on empty."

TRY THIS:

Notice one moment this week when your reaction was bigger than its cause.

02

Some stress is left over from earlier.

Ask yourself: how much of this feeling is about the thing in front of me, and how much did I bring in with me? "I'm upset about the dishes" and "I'm exhausted, and the dishes are what I noticed" are different problems.

Some of what we bring in is much older: an understanding from growing up, like "whoever notices the mess has to clean it." If a feeling seems a lot older than the moment, Where your lens came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up) helps you find where it started.

For example: A teenager has a hard day at school, comes home, and explodes because a brother took the phone charger. The charger is the last drop, not the whole tank.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think I brought this in with me. Give me ten minutes."

TRY THIS:

Before you react, ask: "How much of this is from earlier?"

03

Check your stress tank in a minute.

How much are you carrying? measures how full your stress tank is. A higher score means more stress in the tank. Score five things from 0 to 4: sleep, work elsewhere, any unsettled argument, how your body feels, and time pressure today. Add them up and divide by 20. Under 0.30 is low. From 0.30 up to 0.60 is moderate. 0.60 or more is high. If it has been high for a long time, it can start to feel normal, so a quick reading each week is worth it.

For example: A man caring for his wife after surgery scores 0.65 three days in a row. That tells him he needs help, not more effort.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

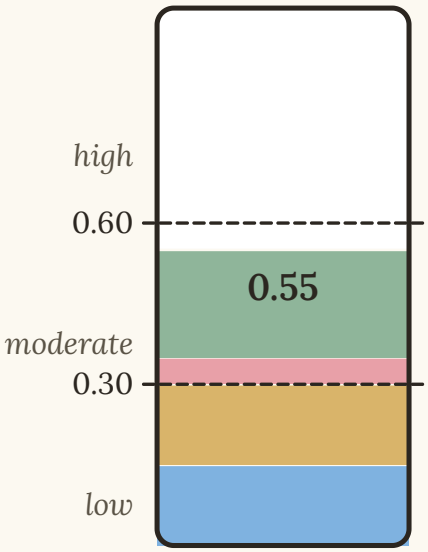
"I checked my tank. I'm in the high band today."

TRY THIS:

Score yourself tomorrow morning, before you look at your phone.

How full is your stress tank?

Score five things from 0 to 4. Add them up, divide by 20.



Sam today

Time pressure today	4
Body: hungry, unwell, in pain	0
Unresolved conflict	1
Workload elsewhere	3
Sleep debt	3
11 ÷ 20	**= 0.55**

Moderate: say it before a hard talk.
"Heads up, I'm carrying more than usual today."

Made-up example from this chapter. The five items and bands are this book's, not a tested questionnaire.

FIGURE 8 How full is your stress tank? Five things scored 0 to 4, added up and divided by 20. Made-up example; the items and bands are this book's.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

How much are you carrying?

Rosa, who shares her mum's care with her brother

How much are you carrying?

Fill this in on your own, about yourself only. Never fill it in for someone else.

Your name *Rosa*

Date *7 October 2026*

The checklist

0 = Not at all · 4 = Very true

Sleep debt (less rested than usual)

0 1 2 (3) 4

Workload elsewhere (job, school, caregiving)

0 1 2 3 (4)

Recent unresolved conflict (any source)

0 (1) 2 3 4

Physical state (hungry, sick, in pain)

0 1 (2) 3 4

Time pressure today specifically

0 1 2 (3) 4

YOUR LOAD SCORE

Your load today
High load (13 out of 20 points)

What to do
Put off anything that doesn't need deciding in the next hour. If you need to settle first, the Calm-Down Kit is made for this.

If it can't wait
If what you're carrying can't wait, like caring for someone who is ill, that's a sign to get more help, not to try harder: ask one person for one specific thing this week, and look into respite care.

Filled most by
sleep debt, workload elsewhere, time pressure today. Conditions, not character.

Load score
0.65 out of 1.00

Optional

☑ Some of what I'm carrying is caring for someone

Anything you want to name before talking
Mum's hospital appointment moved to Thursday, and I'm the one driving.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Higher means more load. Rosa scores only herself; her brother fills in his own.

Fill in your own: How much are you carrying?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02)

04

Three everyday states.

Calm and connected. Revved up. Running on empty. Knowing which one you're in tells you whether now is a good time to talk. The Nervous System Ladder (spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks), a thirty-second self-check, helps you make a best guess. These labels come from polyvagal

theory, whose main claims are still debated by scientists. Here they are only everyday words, not a medical model.

For example: In a long-distance couple, one partner takes the video call at midnight his time. He is often running on empty. They move the hard talks to weekend mornings.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I'm revved up right now. Can we talk after a walk?"

TRY THIS:
Find one body clue for each state, like a tight jaw for "revved up."

05

There are seven angles on the same moment.

Tiredness, time pressure, history, what home was like growing up, your sense of fairness, how you communicate, and stress from outside. Many arguments are two people looking from different angles, each sure the other sees what they see. The See it from their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/perspective-shifter) page (the Perspective Shifter), built on these seven angles, helps you picture how the same moment might look from the other side, with questions to ask instead of guesses.

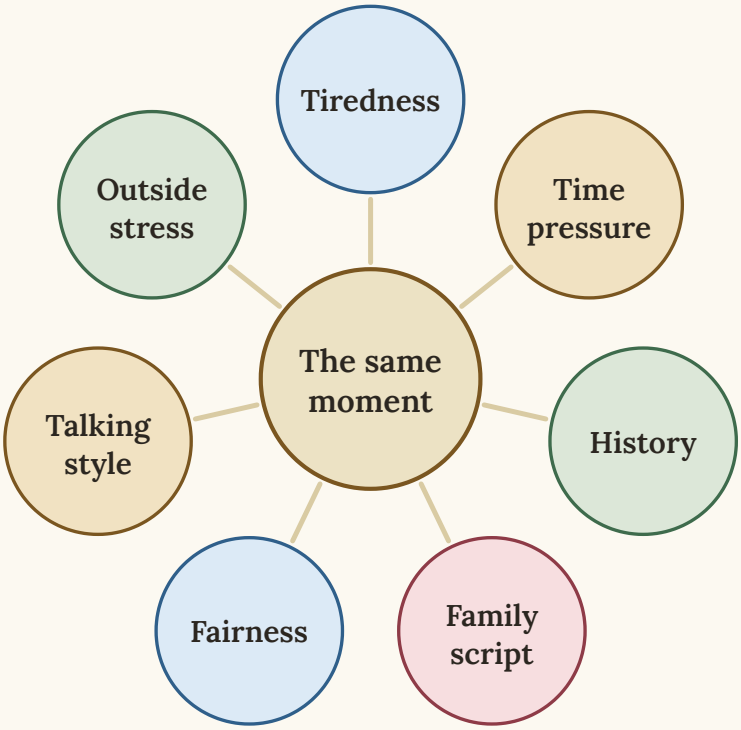
For example: Planning the holidays, one parent sees it from family habit ("We always go to my mum's"). The other sees it from fairness ("We went to yours last year").

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Which angle are you seeing this from?"

TRY THIS:
Guess which of the seven angles you look from most often.

Seven angles on the same moment

Which one are you looking from right now?



An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict.
Name your own. Ask about theirs.

Illustration. The seven angles are this book's; the Perspective Shifter page uses the same seven.

FIGURE 9 Seven angles on the same moment. An angle is a place to stand, not a verdict: name your own, and ask about theirs.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

See it from their side (the Perspective Shifter)

Hana, about her friend Lou

See it from their side

1. What happened?

I asked Lou if she was still coming to my birthday dinner, and she just replied "maybe".

2. Who are they to you?

Partner Family Roommate *Friend* Coworker Co-parent

My teen or child Someone else

3. What state might they have been in?

Calm and connected Revved up *Running on empty* I'm not sure

4. What might have been going on around them?

A long or hard day *Little sleep* Rushed or late Money worries

Caring for someone Not feeling their best A noisy or crowded place

Other people were there *It was a text or message* It was late at night

5. How are they wired?

They notice tone a lot They take words literally *They need time to process*

They think out loud They're very direct They hint rather than say

They like a plan Noise, light or crowds get to them

Their language or culture differs

6. What history might they carry?

This has come up before They grew up with it done differently

It's a sore topic for them They may feel it's unfair

7. What could each of you see? They may have seen or known things you didn't

their whole day and workload *a message, call or news you didn't see*

something they had already planned or done how it looked from where they stood

a promise someone else made them how they were feeling inside

You may have seen or known things they didn't

the planning you had already done *the reason behind your timing*

what you actually meant how tired or stretched you were the part already done

a deadline only you knew about

Neither of you could fully see

each other's tone, in writing what was going on in the other's head

what would happen next what other people had said to each of you

THROUGH THEIR EYES

Running on empty: If they were running on empty, short replies and slow answers are what a tired body does. It can look like not caring when it's only having nothing left.

Caring for someone: Caring for someone else uses up attention you can't see. They may have had less to give than usual.

Questions to check, instead of guessing: "How was your day, before this came up?" "Would it help to think about it and come back to it later?"

A sentence to bridge the gap: "I think we may have been seeing this from different places. On my side, I knew about the reason behind my timing, and I'm not sure that came across. I'm wondering whether, for you, you were running on empty. Could we compare notes? I'd like to understand how it looked to you."

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. These are possibilities to check, not facts about Lou.

Fill in your own: See it from their side (spreadloveandacceptance.com/perspective-shifter)

06

Both views can be true.

You can each be right about what you see and still be looking at different parts of the same thing. The question isn't "Who's right?" but "Which angle are you seeing this from?"

For example: Two adult brothers argue about their late mother's house. One sees memories. The other sees bills. Both are real.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"You're right about what you see. Can I tell you what I see?"

TRY THIS:

Say the other person's view back to them before you give yours.

07

Say it instead of making each other guess.

Before a hard conversation, each of you says how full your stress tank is and which angle you're seeing things from. It works best before you start, not in the middle.

For example: Two coworkers start a tense meeting with one sentence each about their tank and angle. The meeting is shorter, and calmer.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Before we start: I'm about half full today, and I'm seeing this from the time angle."

TRY THIS:

Use that one-line opener once this week.

08

A full tank means "later," not "never."

A high score is a reason to pause, never a way out of the talk. Say when you'll come back, and the Calm-Down Kit (spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11) can help in the meantime. After your calming steps, check your tank again. Under 0.50, go back at the time you said. From 0.50 to 0.59, if you still feel hot, take another round. Still 0.60 or more after two rounds? That's okay. Pick a new time, and say when.

For example: A dad and his 14-year-old get heated about phone time. He says, "I'm too wound up. Let's talk at seven." At seven, he knocks on her door.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I need a break. I'll come back at seven. I promise."

TRY THIS:

Whenever you pause, name the time you'll come back.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. Your stress tank is the only one you can empty. You can't calm someone else's tank for them, and pouring yours into theirs leaves two empty tanks. Protect yours: rest, say "later," and give energy where it's met. When both tanks are full, the kindest thing you control is the timing. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

MONDAY MORNING

You both look at the same pile of mail on the table. One of you sees a to-do list. The other sees proof that nobody else ever opens the mail. Same pile. Two different pictures.

Words this chapter uses

- **Stress tank:** how much stress you are already carrying, before this moment even starts.
- **Leftover stress:** the part of a feeling you brought in from somewhere else, like poor sleep or a hard day.
- **This-moment stress:** the part caused by what is in front of you right now.
- **Angle:** the point of view you are seeing a moment from, like tiredness or fairness.
- **How much are you carrying?:** a free one-minute worksheet that scores your stress tank.
- **Calm-Down Kit:** a short plan for stepping away well and coming back.

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Know how full your stress tank is, and which angle you are seeing from, before you judge a moment.

- **Between you and others:** Choose the timing, pause and come back. Your state shapes how the other person's words land, so say it out loud, and ask which angle they are seeing from.

On your own: reading your own tank

A full tank makes small things feel big. On your own, the most useful habit is a one-minute reading of your battery before you react.

- Check your battery for a few mornings in a row and look for a pattern.
- Before a hard moment, ask yourself how much of this is leftover from earlier.
- Decide on a calm day what settles you, so it's ready when you need it.

For example: Living alone after a breakup, Sam noticed she snapped at her sister every Monday. Her mornings showed why: Sunday nights were her worst sleep of the week. See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Mondays are hard for me. Can we talk on Tuesday instead?"

> IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:
> Step 1: check your battery (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 4: plan what settles you · Part One: what settles you (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth) · The whole book on staying calm (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-calm)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 6 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface (page 12) or the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about)):

- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): The autonomic nervous system runs stress and rest without asking you.
- **Psychology** (Tune how you send and receive): Leftover stress versus this-moment stress, family scripts and communication styles: the angles

you see a moment from.

- **Philosophy** (Tune how you send and receive): Two true views of the same thing (the Blind Men and the Elephant), and the Second Arrow: what happened is the first arrow, and the story we add is the second.
- **Holistic therapies** (Read your state first): Body first, argument second.
- **Behavioural science** (Read your state first): Say it before the talk, with a named time to come back. Practise small routines on calm days.
- **Economics** (See the whole load): A tank that's nearly full has no room to spare.

Two fields, one idea: Philosophy + Neurobiology. What happened is the first arrow. The story we add is the second. A full stress tank makes that second arrow easier to add, so say your tank and your angle out loud first.

In real life

- **Partners:** After a bad night's sleep, "What's for dinner?" sounds like "Why haven't you taken care of dinner?"
- **Family:** A parent asks about your job search. They see it from the angle of worry. You see it from the angle of an old pattern: "They've never trusted me."
- **Roommates:** Loud music at 11pm. One roommate sees it as a fairness issue. The other grew up in a noisy house and honestly didn't notice.
- **Coworkers:** A late-night email. The sender was clearing their inbox. The reader, who is already stretched, feels pressure to answer right away.
- **Two moms:** One comes home from a hard shift to a toddler's meltdown. Her "I can't do this" is about the shift, not the toddler or her wife. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).
- **More than two partners:** In a home of three, a check-in round where everyone says their tank first stops two people guessing about the third. See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).
- **Foster and kinship carers:** After a contact visit, a child's tank is often full. A slammed door that evening may be about the visit, not the carer. See Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).

- **A child with ADHD:** The end of a school day can leave the tank brim full. Big talks go better after food and rest. See When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids).
- **Two faiths:** A festival can mean joy to one partner and pressure to the other. Same day, two angles. See Two faiths, one family (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths).
- **Coming out:** A parent's silence may be shock, not rejection. Your own tank may be full for weeks afterwards. See Coming out (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I think my tank was full before you walked in. Can we start again?"

Common mix-ups

- **"A big reaction means it was a big deal."** Sometimes. Often it means the tank was already full.
- **"A high score is an excuse."** It's a note to come back later, not a pass to skip the talk.
- **"I can tell how full their tank is."** Only they can say. Each person scores only themselves.
- **"Pausing is the same as the silent treatment."** A pause has a time to come back. The silent treatment doesn't. Always say when.
- **"If we see it differently, one of us is wrong."** You may just be standing at different angles.
- **"Naming my angle means giving up my point."** It just helps the other person see where your point is coming from.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't think you're wrong. I think we're standing in different places. Can we swap for a minute?"

Two homes: co-parenting after a split

Children carry two homes, and changeover day fills their tank. Being quiet, clingy or cross for a few hours after a handover is common. It usually isn't a sign that something is wrong at the other home.

- **Landing time:** a snack, something familiar, and no questions about the other home for the first hour.
- **The child is never the messenger.** Adult news goes adult to adult.
- **Money:** follow any formal arrangement. Split the extras by a ratio you agree, keep one list, and settle up once a month.
- **With an ex, share the band, not the story:** "I'm in a heavy week. Could we swap Wednesday?" Your private life stays yours.
- **An ex who won't cooperate but isn't dangerous:** try parallel parenting. Written messages only, short and business-like, handovers at school, and your own list for your own home.
- **New partners:** the parent stays the owner of anything involving the other home. A step-parent starts as a friendly adult, not the one who tells the children off.

For example (made up): Harriet gives Freya, 8, and Arlo, 5, an hour of toast and blankets when they come back from their dad's. She stopped asking "What happened at Dad's?" at the door. Sunday evenings got calmer.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE (A BUSINESS-LIKE MESSAGE):
> "Hi Dylan. Freya's school trip is on 6 November and costs £24. I've paid it and put it on the extras list. Thanks, Harriet."

If you are afraid of your ex, a shared plan isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

If only one of you wants to try this

You can do all of this on your own side. Check your own tank. Name your own angle. Pause and come back on time. The other person doesn't have to use the words for it to help. Often, when one person starts saying it out loud, the other starts to as well.

For example: A daughter visits her dad every Sunday, and every week they clash over his health. She starts each visit with "I'm a bit tired today, so if I go quiet, it's not you." He never scores anything. The visits still get calmer.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I've been trying something. I just tell you how my day was before we talk about the hard stuff."

TRY THIS:

Start your next hard talk with one sentence about your own tank, and nothing about theirs.

A note on safety: A full tank explains a reaction. It never excuses shouting, threats or hurting anyone. If someone's "stress" often turns into fear for you, that isn't a tank problem. These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If sharing how you feel ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

More for your situation

Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting) · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill) · Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room) · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

TRY THIS:

Before your next hard conversation, check how full your own tank is.

Score the five things in How much are you carrying?, add them up and divide by 20.

Then say one sentence out loud, such as: “My stress tank’s about half full today, and I’m mostly seeing this from the time-pressure angle.”

If either of you scores 0.60 or more, put off anything that doesn’t need deciding in the next hour. Agree on a time to come back, and keep it.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **A full tank overflows.** Stress left over from earlier makes small things feel big.
- ✓ **Check your tank in a minute,** and say the band out loud instead of making others guess.
- ✓ **Two people can see one moment from different angles,** and both views can be true.
- ✓ **A full tank means “later,” not “never”:** pause, name a time, and come back.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 2 · Stress and the nervous system
The ladder, flooding and rest — read online

Part Three · Chapter 3 · How we see each other
The angles and stories behind a reaction — read online

Part Three · Chapter 13 · Anger
What to do in the hot minutes — read online

Part One · Now · Your wiring, weather and words
Checking your own weather first — read online

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 3: notice how much each of you is carrying
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying

IV

PART TWO · CHAPTER IV

Two kinds of fair: equal vs fair at home

Agree on what "fair" means before you argue about it, and give a comment a moment to land before you answer it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. There are two kinds of fair
2. Fair by results
3. Fair by promises
4. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner
5. Covering is kind. Say it out loud
6. Let a comment land before you react
7. Notice, name, decide
8. Keep the two questions apart
9. Each idea in everyday life
10. Inside you, and between you
11. On your own: your own kind of fair
12. The fields behind this chapter
13. In real life
14. Common mix-ups
15. Money between you
16. A couple and a housemate
17. More for your situation
18. A note on safety

IN SHORT:

- **There are two kinds of fair:** by results (did it all get done?) and by promises (did each of us do what we agreed?). Agree which one you're using.
- **Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.** Covering for someone is kind when you say it out loud.
- **Let a comment land before you react:** notice it, name it, then decide what to say.
- **Keep the two questions apart:** "Was the job done?" is about a fact; "Did that comment hurt?" is about a feeling.

THE SAME ARGUMENT, TWICE A MONTH

One of you counts hours. The other counts who noticed the job needed doing. You're both counting honestly, in two different currencies, and then arguing about the exchange rate.

01

There are two kinds of fair.

"Did everything get done?" and "Did each of us do what we said we'd do?" Both are reasonable. Friction starts when each of you is using a different one without realising.

02

Fair by results.

This kind judges by outcomes: did the right things get done, by whoever had the time or energy? It's flexible and easy-going. Done carefully, it counts the cost to whoever covered, but done carelessly, it can hide who is always stepping in.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

The Lemonade Stand: the Money tab

Grace and Ruth, a couple with different incomes

Money (optional)

One line per cost. Put what each person actually paid.

Currency
£ (pounds)

Bill	Grace paid (£)	Ruth paid (£)	How it's shared
Rent	1,100	700	*Shared, split*
Power and water	160	0	*Shared, split*
Internet and phones	0	90	*Shared, split*
Groceries	300	250	*Shared, split*

	Grace brings in (£)	Ruth brings in (£)	How it's shared
Pay	4,200	2,800	*Money coming in*

THE SUMMARY

Each person's total: Grace £1,560; Ruth £1,040.

Coming in: £7,000 (Grace £4,200, Ruth £2,800). After shared bills: £4,400 left.

Two ways to split the shared bills. Split evenly: Ruth would put in £260 more · Split by income (60/40): it already comes out even. Pick whichever feels fair to you.

Even isn't always the fair answer (incomes and rooms differ), so treat this as a starting point, not a verdict.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. Money is a fair topic only where nobody controls the other's money.

Fill in your own: The Lemonade Stand (Money tab)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/lemonade-stand)

03

Fair by promises.

This kind asks whether each person did the jobs they agreed to own. It's clear and steady, but it can feel rigid in a week when life gets in the way.

04

Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

The owner is the person who does the job, start to finish. A second name on the list is a backstop who notices if it slipped and gently checks in, never a supervisor. (It can be the same person.) If it's your job, the question is whether you did it, not whether someone else quietly covered for you. That protects the person who keeps filling the gaps.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

One owner per job

Dee and Mark, foster carers

One owner per job: caring for a child in care

Person A
Dee

Person B
Mark

Date of this list
4 October 2026

The split you agreed (optional)
Dee works three days; Mark works full time

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Roughly how long?	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Social worker visits	*Monthly*	1.5	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Mark joins by video when he can*
Reviews and meetings	*As needed*	2	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Dee books and preps; Mark comes to the big ones*
Daily log and placement paperwork	*Daily*	0.5	*Dee*	*Mark*	*Mark writes it on Dee's work days*
Contact visits and calls with their family	*Weekly*	1.5	*Mark*	*Dee*	*Saturday mornings*
School liaison (designated teacher, plans)	*As needed*	1	*Dee*		
Being there after contact	*As needed*	1	*Mark*	*Dee*	*Quiet tea, no questions*
Health and therapy appointments	*As needed*	1.5	*Dee*		
Training and support group	*Monthly*	2	*Mark*		*Mark's turn this term*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
8 of 8. Every job has an owner.

How the jobs are spread
Counted by how often each job comes round, and by size or time where you gave it: Dee 61% · Mark 39%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Dee works three days; Mark works full time". Does this match it? It's a starting point for a talk, not a scorecard.

☑ We're agreed on this

Who agreed (optional)
Dee and Mark

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. "Being there after contact" is on the list because hidden work counts.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (caring for a child in care)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

05

Covering is kind. Say it out loud.

Helping out when the owner can't is lovely. Just mention it, so the help is seen: "I put the bins out this week, since you were away." Help that stays silent turns into unseen work, and unseen help slowly becomes expected (see Complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency)).

06

Let a comment land before you react.

When a remark hits harder than it should, say "Give me a second." The idea is borrowed loosely from brain science, where the brain turns down sounds and sensations automatically, in a fraction of a second. This book's pause is different: a few seconds you choose to take on purpose. Let the spike pass, then decide whether it needs an answer now, later or not at all.

07

Notice, name, decide.

Notice it landed hard. Name it kindly: "That hit harder than you probably meant." Then, once you've settled, decide how to reply. Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands) helps with the words.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

Say it so it lands

Carla, who runs a café with her business partner Femi

Say it so it lands

Your name
Carla

Date
8 October 2026

Before you speak or send: fact, feeling, ask

Use it on one thing that actually stung.

Raw reaction
Great, so I'm doing the stock order on my own again.

What's the fact underneath this? (One sentence, no adjectives.)
The stock order for the café wasn't placed by Tuesday noon, and I placed it at 4.

What's the feeling underneath this? (Frustrated, tired, unseen, rushed…)
I felt stretched thin, and a bit alone with it.

What's the actual ask? (What do you want to happen next, specifically?)
Could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

Before you react: four quick checks

Is this about a specific, nameable task or event?

(Yes) No

Would I read this the same way if I weren't already carrying a lot?

Yes No (Not sure)

Is there a neutral interpretation that also fits what was said?

(Yes) No

Am I responding to their words, or to a pattern from a past conversation?

(*Their words*) A past pattern

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ways to say it

Quick one, no rush: could you own the Tuesday stock order from next week, with me as backup when you're at the bank?

Suggestions

Your own load is part of how this reads. A few hours, or a night's sleep, often changes how it reads. There's a kinder reading that also fits. Try asking about it first: "Did you mean ___, or ___?"

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. The raw reaction stays on the sheet, not in the message.

Fill in your own: Say it so it lands (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-09)

08

Keep the two questions apart.

"Was the job done?" is a question about a fact. "Did that comment hurt?" is a question about a feeling. Both matter. Answer them one at a time, not in the same argument.

Each idea in everyday life

The sections above say what each idea means. Here each one gets a real-life example, words you could say, and one small step.

1. Two kinds of fair

For example: Priya and Jo share a dorm room. Priya thinks it's fair if the room is tidy by Friday, whoever tidies. Jo thinks it's fair if each keeps their own half clean. See Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"When you say fair, do you mean it all gets done, or that we each do our bit?"

TRY THIS:

Each finish this sentence, then compare: "To me, a fair week is one where..."

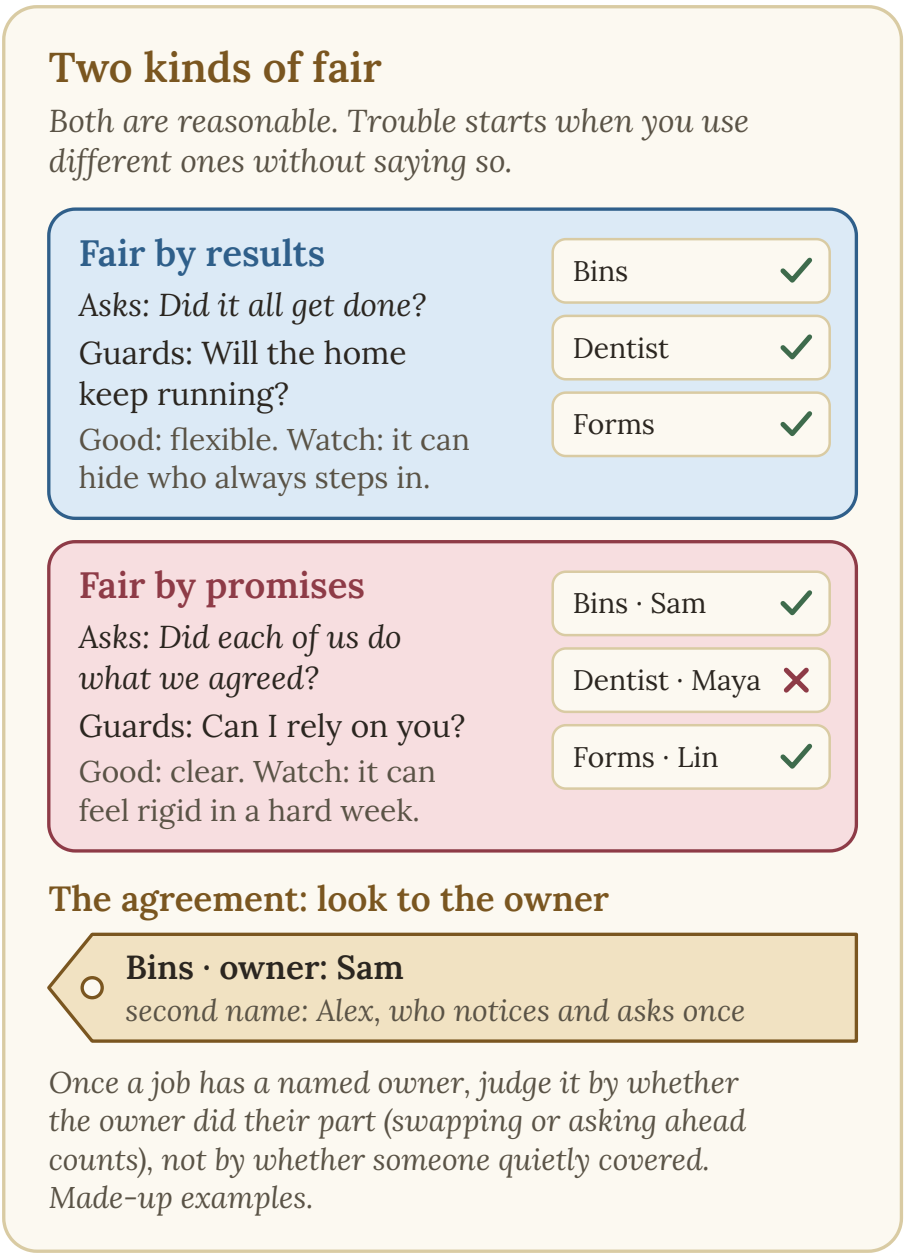


FIGURE 10 Two kinds of fair. Both are reasonable; trouble starts when people use different ones without saying so. Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.

2. Fair by results

For example: A grandmother is raising her grandchildren. Her grown-up son helps "wherever it's needed" when he's home. The house runs, but she

is always the one who notices what's needed. See Kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I like that we're flexible. Can we also check who ends up stepping in most?"

TRY THIS:
For one week, mark every job you picked up that wasn't planned.

3. Fair by promises

For example: Two business partners run a café. One owns the ordering, the other the staff rota. When the rota is late, they ask the rota owner, not "the team."

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"It's my job, and I can't do it this week. Could you take it, and I'll take the bins?"

TRY THIS:
Name one job that is "sort of everyone's." Agree who owns it for a month.

4. Look to the owner

For example: In a stepfamily, the 13-year-old owns feeding the dog, and his stepmom is the second name. At 7pm the bowl is empty. She says, "Dog's dinner?" once. She doesn't do it for him, and she doesn't lecture.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"This one's yours, start to finish. I'll only remind you if it slips."

TRY THIS:
Pick one job that causes friction and write two names next to it.

5. Covering out loud

For example: Two grown-up sisters take turns driving their dad to appointments. When one covers, she texts: "I took Dad Thursday since you had the late shift. Just so you know."

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Thank you for covering that. How was it for you?"

TRY THIS:
Next time you cover a job, mention it in one plain sentence, the same day.

6. Let a comment land

For example: A nurse comes home from a night shift. Her husband says, "Oh, you're up." She hears "at last," but says, "Give me a second, I'm very tired." He meant he was glad to see her. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"That landed hard. Let me think before I answer."

TRY THIS:
Agree on your "give me a second" phrase today, on a calm day.

7. Notice, name, decide

For example: A teenager tells her dad, "You never listen." He feels his chest tighten (notice). He says, "That stings, and I want to hear you properly" (name). He decides it needs a real talk tomorrow (decide). See Teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I want to answer that, just not this minute. Can we talk at eight?"

TRY THIS:
Put the three words somewhere you'll see them, like the fridge.

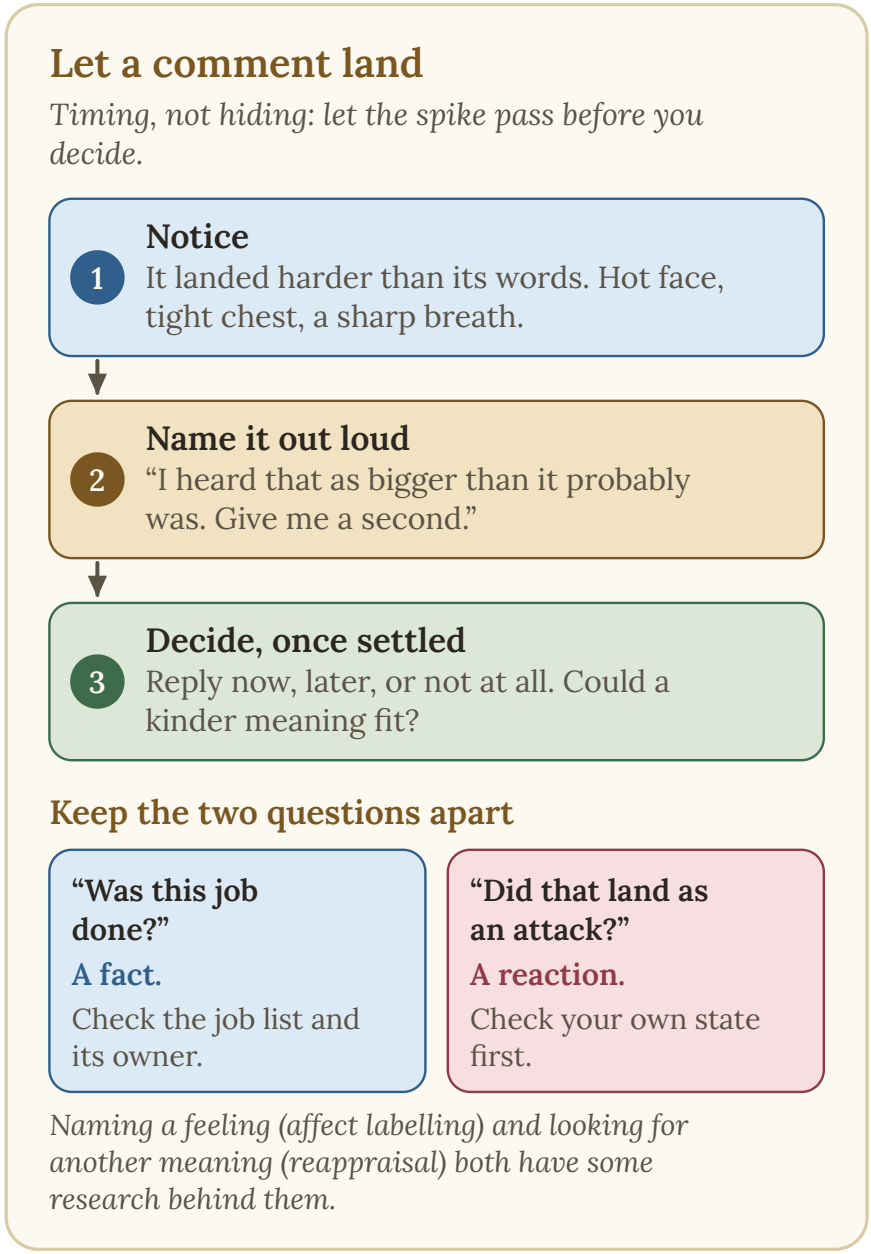


FIGURE 11 Let a comment land before you react: notice, name, decide. And keep the fact question apart from the feeling question.

8. Keep the two questions apart

For example: Separated parents share the kids across two homes. The bag came back without the school shoes (a fact). The text about it felt cold (a

feeling). They sort the shoes first. See Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Can we sort the shoes first, and come back to how that text felt?"

TRY THIS:

When a talk tangles, ask, "Fact or feeling?" and finish one first.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You control whether, when and how you bring something up, and whether you cover a job out loud. How the other person responds is theirs. If you cover again and again with no thanks and no change, match the energy: cover less, and say so kindly. Fair by promises only works when both people keep theirs. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

THE WEEKLY CATCH-UP

Sam and Alex share a home. Alex owns the bins, but Alex works late on Tuesdays, and Sam has quietly taken it out three weeks running. At the catch-up, Sam mentions it. Alex says Tuesday nights aren't realistic with the late shifts. They agree to try a swap for the rest of the month: Sam takes the bins, and Alex takes the recycling and the weekly grocery order. They'll settle it at the monthly look-back in Chapter V (page 106).

WEDNESDAY, 7PM

"Thanks for doing the dishes," one of you says, a little flatly. It was meant as a thank-you. It sounded like a criticism. Before you know it, you've replied to the criticism, and now there really is one.

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Notice which kind of fair comes naturally to you, and notice the quiet habit of covering for others without saying so. When a comment stings, check your own state before you answer.
- **Between you and others:** Give each job one clear owner instead of blaming. Watch how unowned jobs slide toward one person, and keep things steady by mentioning help out loud and saying thank you.

On your own: your own kind of fair

Fair starts with knowing what fair means to you, and which jobs are truly yours.

- Write down what fair means to you, in one sentence.
- List the jobs you own, and the ones you picked up without ever agreeing.
- Practise letting a comment land before you answer, then reply with a fact, a feeling and an ask.

For example: Dev lives alone and has his kids every other weekend. His line: "Fair is not doing their jobs just because I miss them." See On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own).

TRY THIS:

Pick one job you took on without agreeing. Keep it on purpose, or raise it on a calm day.

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:

Step 5: find words for what you feel (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Step 6: kind ways to say no · Part One: where your sense of fair came from (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then) · The whole book on sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-share-the-load)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 6 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface (page 12) or the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about)).

- **Philosophy** (Fix the setup, not the person): Two old ideas behind fairness: judging by outcomes (consequentialist) and judging by promises (deontological).
- **Business** (Fix the setup, not the person): Look to the owner.
- **Economics** (Notice the quiet incentives): Two people keeping score in two currencies, then arguing about the exchange rate.
- **Neurobiology** (Read your state first): How the brain turns down sounds and sensations, borrowed loosely. In the brain it is automatic and takes a fraction of a second; here it's a few seconds you choose to take.
- **Aromatherapy** (Read your state first): For some people, a familiar scent or a calmer room is a quick cue to slow down. Where and when you talk is part of the method.
- **Psychology** (Notice the quiet incentives): Why a flat "thanks" can be heard as sarcasm, and why covering turns sour only when it's silent.

Two fields, one idea: Philosophy + Business. People can mean two different things by "fair." A job list with one owner per job makes it simple: check the job, not the person.

In real life

- **Partners:** One counts hours spent cleaning. The other counts all the planning that happened before anyone picked up a cloth. Both are real work, so put the planning on the list too, in minutes.
- **Parents:** Older kids can own age-sized jobs too, like feeding the cat or packing their own lunch. Put their name on the list, with a parent as the second name.
- **Family:** One sibling visits a parent every week. Another pays for extra help. Each thinks they're doing their share, in a different currency.
- **Roommates:** One wants a fixed schedule. The other prefers "whoever's free does it." Neither is lazy. They just use different kinds of fair.

- **Coworkers:** One person quietly fixes everyone else's slides before the meeting. Because it always gets done, nobody knows it was ever a problem.
- **More than two partners:** In a home with three adults, the one who works from home is always the one who "can." See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).
- **Different hours:** Someone who works nights sleeps in the day. Being home isn't being free. See Different hours.
- **When one is ill:** Share by energy, not hours, with a backup agreed for low days. See When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).
- **Friends:** One friend always hosts, and nobody thanks them anymore. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I think we're counting in different ways. Can we put both on the list?"

TRY THIS:

Read the example closest to your home to the other person, and ask, "Does this sound like us?"

Common mix-ups

- **"If it got done, there's no problem."** Someone may be paying for that in time and energy.
- **"Holding the owner to it is being strict."** It's just keeping the agreement you both made. That's kinder than quiet resentment.
- **"Letting a comment land means ignoring it."** It's about timing, not about swallowing your feelings.
- **"'Give me a second' is rude."** It's a way of taking the other person seriously enough to answer well.
- **"One kind of fair is the right one."** Both are reasonable. What matters is agreeing which one you'll use.
- **"The owner is the boss of that job."** The owner does the job. They don't direct everyone else, and the second name isn't a supervisor.
- **"I covered for months, so now I can bring it all up."** A long list lands as a bill. Mention covering as it happens.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't think either of us is wrong. I think we've been using different rulers."

Money between you

Money is where the two kinds of fair meet most often. Three common ways to share it:

- **All shared:** both incomes go into one pot.
- **Separate:** each keeps their own money and pays agreed bills, often half each. That's fair by promises: the same rule for both.
- **Proportional:** each puts into a shared pot in line with what they earn, and keeps the rest. That's fair by results: each is left with a similar share.

Many couples mix them: a joint account for bills and food, and some money each that nobody has to explain. The right way is the one you both chose with your eyes open. To talk about it, start with your money stories (how

money worked at home when you were growing up), then the numbers, then a "talk first" amount for big buys that applies to both of you. A limit you both chose and both keep is care, not control.

For example (made up): Niamh takes home £2,600 a month and Tariq £1,900. Rent and bills will be £1,500. They split it 58/42, in line with their pay: £870 and £630.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "Can we each say how money worked in our families growing up?"
> "Would half each, or in line with our pay, feel fairer to you?"

A couple and a housemate

A couple sharing a home with a housemate who isn't a partner is a different shape from three equals. Keep two lists: **house jobs** for all three of you (bins, bathroom, bills, the landlord), and **couple jobs** just for the two of you. Decide house questions with all three of you there, not in bed the night before. Hear the housemate first on anything that affects them, keep couple arguments out of shared rooms, and never ask them to be the referee.

For example (made up): Ollie and Hamza share a flat with their friend Bex. They split the rent by room (the couple has the bigger one) and the bills by person. All three hold a short house meeting on the first Sunday of the month.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "That's a house question. Let's decide it when Bex is here."

More for your situation

Each of these pages takes the ideas in this chapter into one kind of relationship. Start from your relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists them all.

- Friends · More than two partners · Sharing a room · Money together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together)

- Foster and kinship families · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts)
- Different hours · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one is ill · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · On my own

TRY THIS:

Agree on what counts as fair on a calm, easy day, not in the middle of a disagreement.

Start by each saying which kind of fair comes more naturally to you: results or promises.

Then pick three regular jobs and write an owner for each in the job list: the person who does it. Add a second name, someone who notices if it slips. It can be the same person.

Finally, agree on a short phrase for when something lands hard, like "Give me a second." Agree that the other person will wait, and that the person who asked for a second will come back to it.

A note on safety

These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If talking about what's fair ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A promise is something both people chose and either can ask to change. Rules one person sets for the other, with checking, punishment or money held back, are control, and that is not your fault. See normal limits and control.

WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH SOMEONE YOU TRUST:

"Things at home don't feel fair, and I'm scared to bring it up. Can I talk it through with you?"

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **There are two kinds of fair:** by results (did it all get done?) and by promises (did each of us do what we agreed?). Agree which one you're using.
- ✓ **Once a job has an owner, look to the owner.** Covering for someone is kind when you say it out loud.
- ✓ **Let a comment land before you react:** notice it, name it, then decide what to say.
- ✓ **Keep the two questions apart:** "Was the job done?" is about a fact; "Did that comment hurt?" is about a feeling.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt
Repair and apologies that land — read online

Part Three · Chapter 4 · How communication works
Letting words land before you reply — read online

Part Three · Chapter 10 · Values, meaning and a good life
Fairness as a value you choose together — read online

Part Three · Chapter 17 · Groups, influence and culture
How a group's norms decide what feels fair — read online

PUT IT TO USE

Six-week program, week 4: talk about it kindly
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01

Say it so it lands
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-09-say-it-so-it-lands

V

PART TWO · CHAPTER V

The monthly look-back: a calm relationship check-in

Once a month, look back for the problems that keep coming back, and fix the setup instead of having the same argument again.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Weekly check-ins miss patterns
2. You need four weeks of notes and one list
3. Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped
4. A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner
5. Sort each repeat into one of three kinds
6. Count the gaps each month
7. Look back even when nothing is slipping
8. It's not a review of either person
9. Keep it short and kind
10. Each idea in everyday life
11. Inside you, and between you
12. In real life
13. Common mix-ups
14. Starting out: before you move in
15. Raising a grandchild (kinship care)
16. More for your situation
17. On your own: a monthly look at yourself
18. The fields behind this chapter

IN SHORT:

- **Weekly check-ins miss patterns.** Once a month, look back over four weeks of notes and your job list.
- **Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.** Anything with two or more gets sorted.
- **A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.** Fix the setup, not the person.
- **Keep it short and kind,** and look back even in the quiet months.

THE THIRD TUESDAY IN A ROW

The bins again. You could have the same ten-minute back-and-forth about Tuesday. Or you could notice that Tuesday has now happened three times, and ask what it is about Tuesdays.

01

Weekly check-ins miss patterns.

One missed job looks like bad luck. The same job missed week after week is a pattern, and it's easiest to see when you look at the whole month. The "audit" here is a careful, friendly look back, more like a self-check than an inspection.

02

You need four weeks of notes and one list.

Bring the month's four weekly notes from Who did what (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-01) (a few lines a week is enough) and your job list from One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-03-one-owner-per-job). That's all. Twenty minutes is usually enough. If either of your stress tanks is high that day (0.60 or more on How much are you carrying? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-02-how-much-are-you-carrying)), move it a day or two.

03

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.

A job "slipped" if it was noticed but not done, only done after being raised more than once, or quietly covered by someone who isn't its owner. Look closely at every job with two or more ✗. Three or four in a month is a real pattern, not just bad luck.

04

A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.

It gets patched every week and never fixed. The owner is the person who does the job, start to finish. The fix is to give the job one owner whose name sticks, or to talk honestly about whether anyone has the time and energy for it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

One owner per job: a list for two homes

Laura and Dan, co-parents in two homes

One owner per job: a list for two homes

Person A
Laura

Person B
Dan

Date of this list
1 October 2026

The split you agreed (optional)
Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5

Who owns each job

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Pack the handoff bag	*Weekly*	*Laura*	*Dan*	*Laura keeps the checklist and the spare kit; whoever hands over packs from it*
Send medicine and chargers with the bag	*Weekly*	*Laura*	*Dan*	*Inhaler: write the last dose time on the card*
School forms and permission slips	*As needed*	*Dan*	*Laura*	
Reply to school emails and apps	*Weekly*	*Dan*		*Dan reads them Sunday night*
Kids' doctor and dentist visits	*As needed*	*Dan*		*Dan books; tells Laura the date*

Job	How often	Owner	Helper or backup	Notes
Homework help (Laura's weeks)	*Daily*	*Laura*		
Homework help (Dan's weeks)	*Daily*	*Dan*		
Activities and sign-ups	*As needed*	*Dan*	*Laura*	*Swimming and Cubs*
Buy clothes as they outgrow them	*As needed*	*Laura*		*Receipts in the shared folder*
Big decisions (school, health, new activities)	*As needed*	*Both (decide together)*		*A decision, not a job: Dan puts it on the list; talked through by phone, never at handoff*

DOES EVERY JOB HAVE AN OWNER?

Jobs with an owner
10 of 10. Every job has an owner.

How the jobs sit across the homes
Counted by how often each job comes round (a daily job about five times a weekly one): Laura's home 52% · Dan's home 47% · Together 1%. You wrote down the split you agreed: "Week on, week off; handoff Sunday at 5". Does this match it? Two homes rarely split evenly, and that can be fair: weekdays and weekends, distance and work all play a part.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. If one parent is afraid of the other, a shared list isn't the right tool: see Not safe at home? on this site.

Fill in your own: One owner per job (two homes)
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)

05

Sort each repeat into one of three kinds.

No clear owner: update the job list. An owner who can't keep up: have a kind, honest talk. A short-term cause, like illness or travel: note it and move on.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

What keeps coming back?
Ash, Robin and Jules, a triad sharing a home

What keeps coming back?

Person A
Ash

Person B
Robin

Person C
Jules

Month
September 2026

Part A: Gather the month's notes

Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped. ✗ = it slipped that week.

Task	Week 1	Week 2	Week 3	Week 4	Times flagged
Cat litter	✗	✗		✗	3
Recycling out on Thursday		✗	✗		2
Book Jules's car service			✗		1
Shared calendar kept up to date	✗	✗	✗	✗	4

Part B: Sort each gap

Sort every task flagged twice or more.

Task	Named owner on the job list?	Classification	Action
Cat litter	No	*Structural gap*	*Robin owns it, with Ash as backup; on the one-owner list tonight*

Task	Named owner on the job list?	Classification	Action
Shared calendar kept up to date	*Yes*	*Capacity issue*	*Ash owns it but is on nights this month; talk on Sunday about what comes off Ash's list*
Recycling out on Thursday	*Yes*	*One-off, no action*	*Two bank holidays moved the day*

PART C: WRAP UP THE AUDIT

Structural gaps found

1. Update One owner per job for each of these in this session.

Capacity issues found

1. Set a time for the conversation. This audit brings it to light, but it doesn't replace it.

One-offs

1

Part D (optional): Thanked, or only noticed when it's missed?

Job	Gets thanked	Only noticed when missed?	One way to notice it
Keeping the calendar	*Rarely*	*Yes*	*Say thanks at Sunday dinner when it's up to date*
Topping up the cat food	*Never*	*Yes*	*A note on the fridge*

A made-up example. Names and details are invented. A task with no owner is a gap in the setup, not a verdict on the person who kept covering it.

Fill in your own: What keeps coming back? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04)

06

Count the gaps each month.

Write down how many gaps of each kind you found. If the number of jobs with no clear owner falls over several months, the setup is working; one month can be a normal swing. If it keeps rising, something bigger has

changed, and it's worth a talk.

07

Look back even when nothing is slipping.

A month with no gaps is good news, and it's also the month most likely to go unchecked. When something has worked for a while, people stop looking, and nothing breaks on the day that happens. Keep the look-back going on quiet months, and add one question: "*What's something we've stopped noticing or mentioning?*" That is how a look-back guards against complacency (spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency).

08

It's not a review of either person.

You don't add up old hours or punish old mistakes. You can thank someone for what they carried before; you just don't bill for the past. The only question is where the setup isn't working yet, and what you'll try next month.

09

Keep it short and kind.

Start with something that went well. Talk about the job, not the person. If a gap needs a proper talk, set it for another day using Check-ins (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins). If a talk starts going badly, either of you can call a pause, and the person who paused names a time to come back.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE

This week's check-in card

Linda and her grown-up son Jordan, who live together

Our weekly check-in

Week of Oct 5 · Linda and Jordan

Who's checking in (optional)

Linda and Jordan

One thing that went well
Jordan cooked twice, and we ate together on Thursday.

One thing that felt heavy
The bathroom, again. And Mum's back was bad all week.

One small thing to try next week
Jordan owns the bathroom on Saturdays. Linda stops checking it.

Our next check-in
Sunday after dinner

Any jobs that slipped or came up again this week? (optional)

Dishes · Laundry · Trash and recycling · Groceries · Cooking · *Cleaning the bathroom* · Paying the bills · Planning and remembering

ON THE CARD

One topic at a time. We're on the same side. Tick a job once it has one owner.

A made-up example. Names and details are invented.

Fill in your own: This week's check-in card (spreadloveandacceptance.com/check-ins)

Each idea in everyday life

The sections above say what each idea means. Here each one gets a real-life example, words you could say, and one small step.

1. Weekly check-ins miss patterns

For example: Four flatmates. Each week the bathroom bin overflowed, and each week it looked like bad luck. Looking at the whole month showed it happened every single week.

> **WORDS YOU COULD USE:**
> "Can we look at the whole month, not just this week?"

TRY THIS:

Pick a monthly date now, like the last Sunday, and put it in both calendars.

2. Four weeks of notes and one list

For example: A couple on different shifts keep their weekly notes in one shared note on their phones. They do the look-back on the one evening they're both off. See Different hours (spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I'm running on empty today. Can we move the look-back to Thursday?"

TRY THIS:

Choose one place where both of you can find the weekly notes.

3. Mark an ✗ when a job slipped

For example: Two foster carers look back. The reading log was missed three weeks out of four. Three ✗ means it's a pattern, not a bad week. See Foster and kinship families (spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"This isn't about who. It's just which jobs slipped."

TRY THIS:

Mark the ✗ in pencil, together, before anyone explains anything.

4. A repeat usually has no real owner

For example: Three partners share a home. "Whoever's free" does the grocery order, and it was late three times. Nobody owned it, so everybody assumed. See More than two (spreadloveandacceptance.com/more-than-two).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Whose name is next to this one? If nobody's, shall we pick?"

TRY THIS:

For each job with two or more ✗, check that one name is written next to it.

5. Sort each repeat

For example: Separated parents look at the missed homework folder. Was nobody sure which home signs it (no owner)? Is one parent swamped (can't keep up)? Or was it the week she had flu (a one-off)? See Co-parenting (spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"Is this a list problem, a too-much problem, or just a bad week?"

TRY THIS:

Write one of the three kinds next to every repeat before you decide what to do.

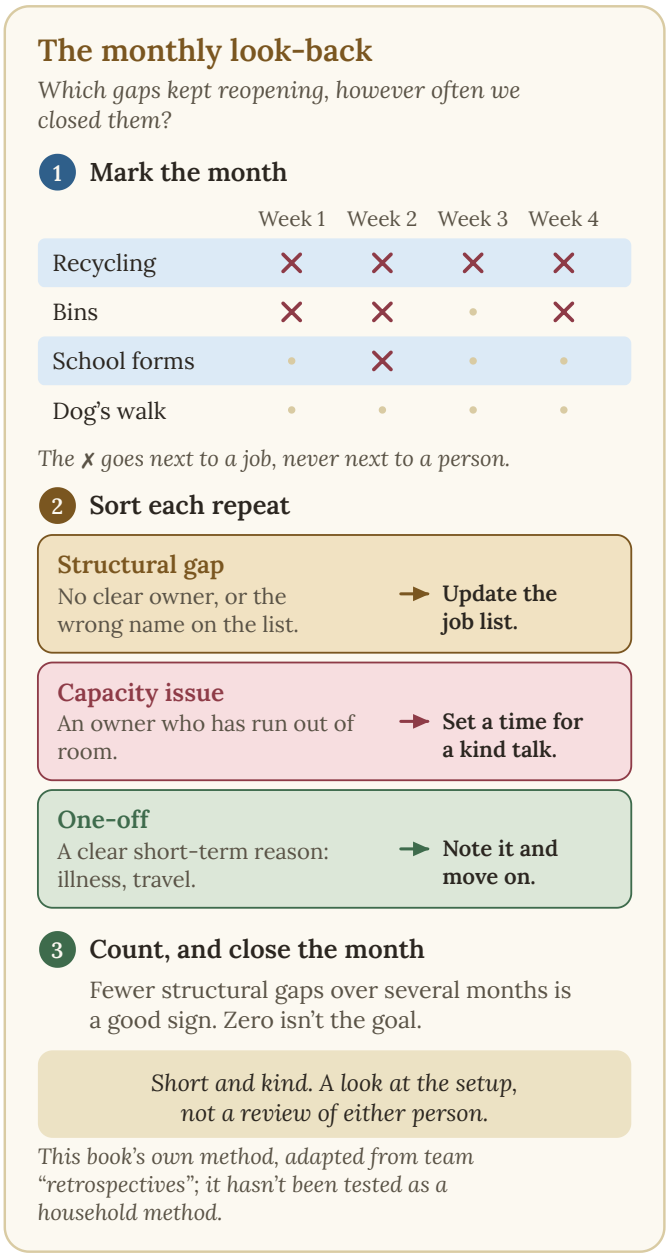


FIGURE 12 The monthly look-back: mark the month, sort each repeat, count and close. The cross goes next to a job, never a person.

6. Count the gaps

For example: Two business partners write their monthly count on a whiteboard in the back office. In March, four jobs had no clear owner. By

June, one did.

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"Let's just write the numbers down and see how they look in three months."

TRY THIS:
Write this month's three numbers on the back page of your notes.

7. Look back on quiet months too

For example: The kids have left home and nothing is slipping. At the look-back, one of them says, "We don't really talk at dinner anymore." Nothing was broken. Something was drifting. See Kids grown and gone (spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"What's something we've stopped noticing or mentioning?"

TRY THIS:
Keep the date on a quiet month, and ask just that one question.

8. Not a review of either person

For example: After a month in hospital, one partner comes home to a long list of what slipped. They thank each other for what each carried instead, and fix only next month. See When one of you is ill (spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:
"I see how much you carried. Let's just set up next month."

TRY THIS:
If you notice yourself adding up past hours, stop and say one thank-you instead.

9. Short and kind

For example: A mum and two teens hold their look-back over pizza. Each says one good thing first. One gap gets a new owner. It's over in fifteen minutes. See Teens (spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"This needs a proper talk. Can we do it Thursday, not now?"

TRY THIS:

Set a timer for twenty minutes, and stop when it rings.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. In the look-back you can only fix the gaps you own, and offer help with the rest. You can't make someone keep a rhythm. Keep the rhythms you can keep, notice which ones are kept in return, and let your effort follow: more where it's shared, less where it isn't, so the rhythm doesn't run on one person's energy. More in Part One: who you are today (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now)

THE LAST SUNDAY OF THE MONTH

Two mugs of tea, four weeks of notes and twenty minutes. You go down the list. Most weeks went fine. Two jobs keep coming up. That's the whole meeting, and it's enough.

Inside you, and between you

- **In you:** Look at your own routines as a setup you can adjust. Spot the easy defaults, like "I'll just do it," that let a gap quietly reopen.
- **Between you and others:** Look at the month together, give repeating gaps a clear owner, and keep count so jobs don't drift back to whoever notices first.

In real life

- **Partners:** Sam and Alex's bins slipped three weeks in a row, because Alex works late on Tuesdays. After a trial swap, they make it official: Sam owns the bins, and Alex takes the recycling and the weekly grocery order, so the hours stay even.
- **Family:** Three siblings keep forgetting to call their dad's landlord about repairs. It turns out nobody ever agreed who would.
- **Roommates:** The recycling overflows every other week. Everyone thought someone else was taking it down.
- **Coworkers:** Meeting notes go missing twice a month. Giving note-taking a named owner fixes it by the next month.
- **Long distance:** A couple in two cities do the look-back by video. Their repeat is "who calls first," so they give it an owner per weekday. See Long distance (spreadloveandacceptance.com/long-distance).
- **Friends:** Two friends notice their monthly dinner has been cancelled three times. Nobody owned booking it. See Friends (spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends).
- **Grandparents and parents:** School pick-ups by grandma slipped twice, both on days she wasn't told about. The gap was the message, not grandma. See Grandparents (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grandparents).

WORDS YOU COULD USE:

"I don't think anyone dropped this. I think nobody ever picked it up."

Common mix-ups

- **"This is where we settle who owes what."** Past hours are never billed to anyone, though you can still say thank you for them. You only fix the setup going forward.
- **"If a job slipped, the owner failed."** The gap might be in the list, in the owner's capacity, or just a one-off week.
- **"One bad week means we should change everything."** Don't make a lasting change because of a short-term cause.
- **"We can skip the weekly checks and just do this."** The monthly look-back only works if the weekly notes feed it.
- **"More gaps this month means we're failing."** One month can be a normal swing, or it can mean life changed. That's a reason to talk, not to worry.
- **"The look-back is for the person who keeps the notes."** It works best when both bring their notes, and both talk.

> **A note on safety:** These tools only work when each person feels free to say no, to ask for a pause, or to keep their own notes private. If looking back together ever feels unsafe, or one of you feels you can't say no, stop using the tools and talk with a trained counsellor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counselling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private hotlines.

A look-back is something you both choose. If one person demands logs of the other's every hour, checks their phone without agreement, or uses the ✗ marks to punish, that is control, not a look-back, and it is not your fault. See Not safe at home? and normal limits and control (spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together).

Starting out: before you move in

New together, and about to share a home? The tools work best now, before habits set. A gentle order, about one step a week:

1. **Week 1:** each write down the rulebook from the home you grew up in (spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up), then swap. Be curious, not judging.
2. **Week 2:** talk about money: your money stories first, then the split (Chapter IV (page 102)).
3. **Week 3:** write your first job list, with one owner per job, thinking jobs included (One owner per job (spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03)).
4. **Week 4:** make a pause plan (spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw) on a calm day.
5. **Week 5:** each name three things that matter most to you about a home (Part Three, Chapter 10 (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values)).
6. **After the move:** log one ordinary week after two weeks, and do your first short look-back after four.

It isn't a test, and it isn't keeping score. It's so neither of you has to guess.

For example (made up): Niamh and Tariq, eight months together, find their families meant different things by "tidy." They agree: kitchen every night, the rest on Sunday.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE:
> "I don't want us to keep score. I just want us never to have to guess. Could we try a few small things before we move?"

Raising a grandchild (kinship care)

Many grandparents and other relatives raise a child whose parents can't, and much of it is about things that keep coming back: cancelled calls, hard evenings after contact, forms. A monthly look-back helps. Some repeats you can own; some, like a parent who misses calls, you can't. For those, own the plan for the evening after.

- **The loyalty bind:** the child may love the parent who can't look after them and you. Tell them they don't have to choose, and don't run the parent down in front of them.

- **Explaining an absent parent:** short, true and kind, in words for their age, and always "it's not your fault."
- **When the parent is your own adult child** and things are hard between you: keep messages about the child short and civil, for the child's sake, and leave the door open.
- **Look after yourself:** ask for respite and join other kinship carers. In England and Wales, the charity Kinship (kinship.org.uk) can help.

For example (made up): Maureen, 63, is raising her grandson Tyler, 9. Her look-back shows his mum's Sunday call fell through three times this month. She plans those evenings (hot chocolate, his football annual) and asks her brother to take Tyler swimming on Sunday afternoons.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE, WITH THE CHILD:
> "Mum loves you. She isn't well enough to look after you right now, and that's not your fault."

More for your situation

A look-back works in every kind of relationship, with small changes. These pages take it into one situation each. Start from your relationship (spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship) lists them all.

- More than two partners · Money together · Gaming and time together (spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together) · Sharing a room (spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room)
- Foster and kinship families · When a child has ADHD (spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids) · Grown-up children (spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children) · Family rifts (spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts) · Kids grown and gone
- Different hours · Coming home (spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home) · When one is ill · Two faiths (spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths) · On my own (spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own) · For counsellors (spreadloveandacceptance.com/for-counselors)

On your own: a monthly look at yourself

Once a month, look back at your own month, kindly. Not a scorecard, more like a weather report.

- What filled your battery this month, and what drained it?
- Which of your limits held, and which slipped?
- Choose one small thing to keep, and one to change next month.

For example: Rosa lives on her own after a divorce. Her monthly look-back shows the same ✗ three weeks running: she skipped her Thursday swim to answer work emails. She moves the emails, not the swim. See On my own.

WORDS YOU COULD USE (TO YOURSELF):
"Not a scorecard. Just this month's weather."

TRY THIS:
On the last day of this month, write three lines: one thing that filled you, one that drained you, one thing to change.

IN THE INDIVIDUAL PROGRAM:
The Individual package and your report (spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path) · Part One: a kind monthly look at yourself (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next-in-depth) · Step 1: check your battery · The whole book on sharing the load (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/topic-share-the-load)

The fields behind this chapter

This chapter draws on 7 of the author's thirteen fields (see the Preface (page 12) or the About page (spreadloveandacceptance.com/about)):

- **Finance** (See the whole load): The month-end close: check the plan against the log, so next month starts clean.
- **Business** (Fix the setup, not the person): The audit habit, as a friendly self-check. A job that keeps slipping usually has no real owner.

- **Economics** (Notice the quiet incentives): Past hours can't be handed back, so they aren't billed.
- **Behavioural science** (Notice the quiet incentives): Three or four slips in a month is a pattern that's easy to miss week by week.
- **Psychology** (Tune how you send and receive): Say a pattern as a repeated fact, not a verdict.
- **Philosophy** (Fix the setup, not the person): The Ship of Theseus: a ship rebuilt plank by plank is still the same ship. Your agreements can be rebuilt and still be yours.
- **Holistic therapies** (Read your state first): Body first, argument second. A calm look-back a few days late beats a tense one on time.

Two fields, one idea: Finance + Business. Once a month, look back like an audit: which jobs kept slipping? A job that keeps slipping usually needs an owner, not more effort.

TRY THIS:

Put a relaxed 20-minute date on the calendar, once a month.

Until then, keep your weekly Who did what notes somewhere you can both find them.

At the look-back, start by naming one thing that went well this month.

End by writing down how many gaps of each kind you found, so over the next few months you can see if the number is falling.

That's the end of Part Two. The book goes on in Part Three: Understanding people (spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings), chapters on how people work, for anyone. To put Parts One and Two into practice first, try the six-week program (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01): six gentle weeks, with one chapter and one small tool each week.

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Weekly check-ins miss patterns.** Once a month, look back over four weeks of notes and your job list.
- ✓ **Mark an ✗ for each week a job slipped.** Anything with two or more gets sorted.
- ✓ **A problem that keeps coming back usually has no real owner.** Fix the setup, not the person.
- ✓ **Keep it short and kind,** and look back even in the quiet months.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Part One · Next · Who you are becoming
The same kind look, on your own — read online

Part Three · Chapter 6 · Habits and change
Why problems come back, and how habits stick — read online

Part Two · Chapter II · Is the split working?
The setup score the look-back feeds — page 47

Part Three · Chapter 11 · Healing after hurt
Repairing what the look-back finds — read online

PUT IT TO USE



Six-week program, week 6: make it last
spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01



What keeps coming back? A monthly look-back
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/wp-04-what-keeps-coming-back

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. More at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Battery
Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, your load: a higher load score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.
For example: After a poor night and a long workday, your load score is high and your battery is low, so a small request feels big.

Calm-Down Kit
The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.
For example: A glass of cold water, a walk to the corner, and three long breaths out.

Carrier wave
The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.
For example: "Fine." can carry calm, hurt or tiredness. The carrier wave tells you which.

Check-in
A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.
For example: "Load today: heavy. Thank you for the dishes. One small thing: the car. My ask: could you fill it up?"

Complacency
Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.
For example: "How was your day?" "Fine." Months go by and nobody has asked a real question.

Drift
Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.
For example: Three busy weeks, no real talk, and small things start to feel big.

Flooded
Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.
For example: "I need twenty minutes. Can we talk again at eight?"

Frequency
Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.
For example: One person answers a text in a minute; the other answers at the end of the day. Neither is wrong.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

For example: Sam owns the recycling: noticing it's full, taking it out and buying the bags.

Pressure

Pressure is the number in Today's Weather that shows how much is pressing on you today. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

For example: A pressure of 40 leaves room in the day; 75 means go gently and leave big things for later.

Retune

To retune is to notice you've fallen out of step with someone and adjust together: slower, softer, or at a better time.

For example: "Can we start that again? I came in too fast."

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

For example: You ask "When will you do it?" calmly. They hear pressure. Nobody meant harm, but it crackles.

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

For example: Your window says "wait," so you ask to talk after dinner instead of right now.

The load

The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

For example: Buying the gift is one job. Remembering the birthday, picking the gift and wrapping it are three more.

Today's Weather

Today's Weather is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

For example: Short night, busy day: the forecast says to keep big talks for tomorrow.

Unbilled debt

Unbilled debt is the work of a shared life that got done but was never noticed or thanked.

For example: You remembered the dentist appointment, and nobody knew there was anything to remember.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

For example: Some people need a plan in writing. Others think best out loud.

Workpaper

A workpaper is a short worksheet. Each person fills in their own, then you read them together.

For example: "Who did what" is a week's log of who did what.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

For example: "Rest is earned" can feel like plain fact, until you notice it was your family's rule.

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Research notes

The 77 studies and books the chapters mention, chapter by chapter, each with what it found in plain words and where to read it. Every entry was checked against the original source. The full list, with notes on how strong each finding is, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

PREFACE TO PART TWO

The work nobody sees

Allen, S. M., & Hawkins, A. J. (1999). *Maternal gatekeeping: Mothers' beliefs and behaviors that inhibit greater father involvement in family work.* Defined maternal gatekeeping along three dimensions and, in 622 dual-earner mothers, classified about one in five as gatekeepers; they did more family work each week and had less equal divisions of labor.
doi.org/10.2307/353894

Clark, M. S., & Mills, J. (1979). *Interpersonal attraction in exchange and communal relationships.* Distinguished communal relationships (benefits given in response to needs) from exchange relationships (benefits given in return for benefits). When people wanted a communal relationship, being repaid in kind reduced attraction.
clarkrelationshiplab.yale.edu/sites/default/files/files/Interpersonal%20attraction%20in%20exchance%20and%20commual%20relationships.pdf

Cowan, C. P., & Cowan, P. A. (1992). *When Partners Become Parents: The Big Life Change for Couples.* Based on the Becoming a Family Project, a long-term study of expectant couples, describes how strain and conflict between partners commonly rise across the transition to parenthood, and tests couples groups as prevention.
openlibrary.org/works/OL92708W

Daminger, A. (2019). *The cognitive dimension of household labor.* Interviews with 35 couples (70 interviews) identified four parts of household "cognitive labor": anticipating needs, identifying options, deciding, and monitoring. Women did more of it overall, especially anticipating and monitoring; deciding was shared more equally. The work was often unseen by both partners.
doi.org/10.1177/0003122419859007

Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968). *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Students who heard another participant apparently having a seizure over an intercom were slower and less likely to report it when they believed other listeners were present, showing diffusion of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

di Leonardo, M. (1987). *The female world of cards and holidays: Women, families, and the work of kinship.* Named "kin work": the cards, calls, visits, gifts and gatherings that keep extended families connected. In the families she studied, it was done mostly by women and often treated as effortless.
doi.org/10.1086/494338

Doss, B. D., Rhoades, G. K., Stanley, S. M., & Markman, H. J. (2009). *The effect of the transition to parenthood on relationship quality: An 8-year prospective study.* Following 218 couples over the first eight years of marriage, those who had a first child showed sudden declines in relationship quality after the birth, on average, compared with couples who did not.
doi.org/10.1037/a0013969

Gordon, A. M., Impett, E. A., Kogan, A., Oveis, C., & Keltner, D. (2012). *To have and to hold: Gratitude promotes relationship maintenance in intimate bonds.* People who felt more appreciated by their romantic partners were more appreciative of their partners in return, and appreciation was linked with relationship maintenance and commitment.
doi.org/10.1037/a0028723

Gordon, A. M., Impett, E. A., Kogan, A., Oveis, C., & Keltner, D. (2012). *To have and to hold: Gratitude promotes relationship maintenance in intimate bonds.* Across cross-sectional, daily, observational and longitudinal studies, people who felt appreciated by their partners were more appreciative in return; appreciative partners were more responsive and committed, and more likely to still be together months later.
doi.org/10.1037/a0028723

Hochschild, A. R. (1983). *The Managed Heart: Commercialization of Human Feeling.* Coined "emotional labor" from a study of flight attendants (and bill collectors) trained to display feelings at work; distinguished surface acting from deep acting.
en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Managed_Heart

Hochschild, A. R., with Machung, A. (1989). *The Second Shift: Working Parents and the Revolution at Home.* Interviews and home observations of dual-earner couples with young children found that working mothers did much more of the housework and childcare, adding up to a large extra load over a year; many couples told themselves stories that the split was fair.
penguinrandomhouse.com/books/310593/the-second-shift-by-arlie-hochschild

Kurdek, L. A. (2007). *The allocation of household labor by partners in gay and lesbian couples.* Among 43 gay and 36 lesbian couples where both partners worked full-time, household tasks were divided more evenly than is typical in heterosexual couples, often by negotiation and specialisation rather than gender.
doi.org/10.1177/0192513X06292019

Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996). *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979). *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

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doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.3.389

Yavorsky, J. E., Kamp Dush, C. M., & Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J. (2015). *The production of inequality: The gender division of labor across the transition to parenthood.* Time-diary data from dual-earner couples showed a gender gap in total work opening up after a first baby: mothers took on most of the added childcare without cutting their paid hours; survey reports overstated how equal things were.
doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12189

Why we get out of tune

Bryant, C. M., Conger, R. D., & Meehan, J. M. (2001). *The influence of in-laws on change in marital success.* Following couples for several years, found that conflict and poorer relationships with in-laws predicted later declines in marital success (stability, satisfaction and commitment).
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2001.00614.x

Carrère, S., & Gottman, J. M. (1999). *Predicting divorce among newlyweds from the first three minutes of a marital conflict discussion.* In 124 newlywed couples, how the first three minutes of a conflict discussion went (more negative and less positive emotion) predicted which couples divorced over the next six years.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1545-5300.1999.00293.x

Gilovich, T., Savitsky, K., & Medvec, V. H. (1998). *The illusion of transparency: Biased assessments of others' ability to read one's emotional states.* In several sets of studies, people overestimated how well others could read their internal states (for example, liars overestimated how detectable their lies were, and people thought their disgust showed more than it did).
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.75.2.332

Gordon, T. (1970). *P.E.T.: Parent Effectiveness Training.* A parenting book and course that popularized 'I-messages': describing your own feelings and the effect of a behavior rather than blaming the other person.
en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Parent_Effectiveness_Training

Kruger, J., Epley, N., Parker, J., & Ng, Z.-W. (2005). *Egocentrism over e-mail: Can we communicate as well as we think?.* Across five experiments, people overestimated how well email recipients would detect their tone (such as sarcasm or seriousness), partly because they found it hard to step outside their own perspective.
doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.89.6.925

Lally, P., van Jaarsveld, C. H. M., Potts, H. W. W., & Wardle, J. (2010). *How are habits formed: Modelling habit formation in the real world.* Following 96 volunteers who repeated a daily behaviour in the same context for 12 weeks, automaticity rose along a curve that levelled off; reaching 95% of each person's plateau took between 18 and 254 days, and missing a single day did not meaningfully set progress back.
doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.674

Lambert, N. M., Fincham, F. D., Stillman, T. F., Graham, S. M., & Beach, S. R. H. (2010). *Motivating change in relationships: Can prayer increase forgiveness?.* In two small experiments with students, people asked to pray for a romantic partner (study 1) or for a friend daily for four weeks (study 2) reported more willingness to forgive that person than people in comparison conditions; in study 2 this went with a rise in selfless concern.
doi.org/10.1177/0956797609355634

Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007). *Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli.* In a brain-imaging study, labelling the emotion in a picture reduced amygdala and other limbic responses compared with other ways of processing the image.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

Mahoney, A. (2010). *Religion in families, 1999–2009: A relational spirituality framework.* Reviewed a decade of peer-reviewed studies on religion in marriage and parent–child relationships, "for better and worse", organising them by how faith may help form, maintain and change family relationships; faith can strengthen family life and can also be a source of strain.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2010.00732.x

Rosenberg, M. B. (1999). *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Compassion (later editions: A Language of Life).* Describes Nonviolent Communication: expressing observations, feelings, needs and requests, and listening for the same in others.
vufind.lboro.ac.uk/Record/562413

Ross, L. (1977). *The intuitive psychologist and his shortcomings: Distortions in the attribution process.* Reviewed the biases of the lay 'intuitive psychologist' and named the fundamental attribution error: underestimating situational causes and overestimating personal dispositions when explaining others' behavior.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60357-3

Savitsky, K., Keysar, B., Epley, N., Carter, T., & Swanson, A. (2011). *The closeness-communication bias: Increased egocentrism among friends versus strangers.* In three experiments, people overestimated how well they communicated with friends and spouses, more than with strangers, and made more egocentric errors following a friend's directions; closeness seemed to relax the checking people do with strangers.
sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0022103110002118

Yoo, S.-S., Gujar, N., Hu, P., Jolesz, F. A., & Walker, M. P. (2007). *The human emotional brain without sleep—a prefrontal amygdala disconnect.* After a night without sleep, the amygdala reacted more strongly to negative pictures and was less connected to the prefrontal cortex.
doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2007.08.007

PART TWO · CHAPTER II

Is the split working?

Cowan, C. P., & Cowan, P. A. (1992). *When Partners Become Parents: The Big Life Change for Couples.* Based on the Becoming a Family Project, a long-term study of expectant couples, describes how strain and conflict between partners commonly rise across the transition to parenthood, and tests couples groups as prevention.
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doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

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doi.org/10.1037/a0013969

Feinberg, M. E., & Kan, M. L. (2008). *Establishing Family Foundations: Intervention effects on coparenting, parent/infant well-being, and parent-child relations.* A randomized trial with 169 expectant first-time couples found that the Family Foundations classes, delivered before and after birth, improved coparenting and some aspects of parent and infant wellbeing at follow-up.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.2.253

Goodhart, C. A. E. (1975). *Problems of monetary management: The U.K. experience.* The original source of "Goodhart's law": a statistical regularity tends to break down once authorities put pressure on it for control purposes.
rba.gov.au/publications/rdp/1990/9013/conference-volumes.html

Hochschild, A. R., with Machung, A. (1989). *The Second Shift: Working Parents and the Revolution at Home.* Interviews and home observations of dual-earner couples with young children found that working mothers did much more of the housework and childcare, adding up to a large extra load over a year; many couples told themselves stories that the split was fair.
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doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.37.3.322

Strathern, M. (1997). *'Improving ratings': Audit in the British University system.* Anthropological commentary on the "audit explosion" in British universities; widely credited as the source of the popular phrasing of Goodhart's law (when a measure becomes a target, it stops being a good measure).
cambridge.org/core/journals/european-review/article/improving-ratings-audit-in-the-british-university-system/FC2EE640C0C44E3DB87C29FB666E9AAB

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (conducted by the U.S. Census Bureau) (None). *American Time Use Survey (ATUS), annual since 2003.* The federal survey of how, where and with whom Americans spend their time, including unpaid housework and childcare; it has run every year since 2003.
census.gov/programs-surveys/atus.html

Yavorsky, J. E., Kamp Dush, C. M., & Schoppe-Sullivan, S. J. (2015). *The production of inequality: The gender division of labor across the transition to parenthood.* Time-diary data from dual-earner couples showed a gender gap in total work opening up after a first baby: mothers took on most of the added childcare without cutting their paid hours; survey reports overstated how equal things were.
doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12189

PART TWO · CHAPTER III

Full tanks and different angles

Amato, P. R. (2001). *Children of divorce in the 1990s: An update of the Amato and Keith (1991) meta-analysis.* Updated a meta-analysis comparing children of divorced and continuously married parents; differences in wellbeing were small on average and persisted in studies from the 1990s.
doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.15.3.355

Emery, R. E. (1982). *Interparental conflict and the children of discord and divorce.* Reviewed evidence that conflict between parents, in married and divorced families, is linked to children's problems, and that the amount and type of conflict matter.
doi.org/10.1037/0033-2909.92.2.310

Hetherington, E. M., & Kelly, J. (2002). *For Better or For Worse: Divorce Reconsidered.* Drawing on long-term studies of about 1,400 families, argues that most children of divorce and remarriage turn out reasonably well, with outcomes varying widely.
wwnorton.co.uk/books/9780393324136-for-better-or-for-worse

Jones, E. E., & Nisbett, R. E. (1971). *The actor and the observer: Divergent perceptions of the causes of behavior.* Proposed the actor-observer hypothesis: people tend to explain their own actions by the situation and others' actions by their dispositions.
krimdok.uni-tuebingen.de/Record/1098932900

Maccoby, E. E., & Mnookin, R. H. (1992). *Dividing the Child: Social and Legal Dilemmas of Custody.* Following more than a thousand separating families for three years, described three patterns of co-parenting among families where children spent time in both homes: cooperative, conflicted and disengaged; most parents avoided legal battles but many found it hard to cooperate.
hls.harvard.edu/bibliography/dividing-the-child-social-and-legal-dilemmas-of-custody

Neff, K. D. (2003). *Self-compassion: An alternative conceptualization of a healthy attitude toward oneself.* Defined self-compassion as three parts: self-kindness instead of harsh judgement, common humanity instead of isolation, and mindfulness instead of over-identifying with painful feelings.
doi.org/10.1080/15298860309032

Neff, L. A., & Karney, B. R. (2009). *Stress and reactivity to daily relationship experiences: How stress hinders adaptive processes in marriage.* Spouses under more stress outside the relationship reacted more strongly to everyday negative experiences within it.
doi.org/10.1037/a0015663

Papernow, P. L. (2013). *Surviving and Thriving in Stepfamily Relationships: What Works and What Doesn't.* Describes "stepfamily architecture" and five common challenges it creates, drawing on research and clinical experience; closeness between stepfamily members typically builds slowly.
routledge.com/Surviving-and-Thriving-in-Stepfamily-Relationships-What-Works-and-What/Papernow/p/book/9780415894388

Ross, L., & Ward, A. (1996). *Naive realism in everyday life: Implications for social conflict and misunderstanding.* Described naive realism: people assume they see the world objectively, so those who disagree must be uninformed, irrational or biased — a dynamic that fuels conflict and misunderstanding.
doi.org/10.4324/9780203773772-6

PART TWO · CHAPTER IV

Two kinds of fair

Adams, J. S. (1965). *Inequity in social exchange.* Founding statement of equity theory: people compare the ratio of what they put in to what they get out with someone else's, and feel tension when the ratios differ.
doi.org/10.1016/S0065-2601(08)60108-2

Allen, S. M., & Hawkins, A. J. (1999). *Maternal gatekeeping: Mothers' beliefs and behaviors that inhibit greater father involvement in family work.* Defined maternal gatekeeping along three dimensions and, in 622 dual-earner mothers, classified about one in five as gatekeepers; they did more family work each week and had less equal divisions of labor.
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doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

Deming, W. E. (1986). *Out of the Crisis.* Deming's case for quality management, arguing that most problems come from the system people work in rather than from individual workers.
eploes.lib2.uniwa.gr/Record/lib2_1%2F6426/Details?lng=el

Deutsch, M. (1975). *Equity, equality, and need: What determines which value will be used as the basis of distributive justice?.* Argued that equity is only one of several justice principles, alongside equality and need, and proposed when groups favour each: equality in cooperative relationships, equity in economic ones, need in caring ones.
data.gesis.org/gesiskg/resource/zis-Deutsch1975Equity

Dew, J., Britt, S., & Huston, S. (2012). *Examining the relationship between financial issues and divorce.* In US national survey data on about 4,500 couples, financial disagreements were the strongest of the disagreement types in predicting later divorce, for both wives and husbands.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3729.2012.00715.x

Klontz, B., Britt, S. L., Mentzer, J., & Klontz, T. (2011). *Money beliefs and financial behaviors: Development of the Klontz Money Script Inventory.* In 422 respondents, beliefs about money clustered into four "money scripts" (money avoidance, money worship, money status and money vigilance), several of which were linked with income and net worth.
doi.org/10.4148/jft.v2i1.451

Kruger, J., Epley, N., Parker, J., & Ng, Z.-W. (2005). *Egocentrism over e-mail: Can we communicate as well as we think?.* Across five experiments, people overestimated how well email recipients would detect their tone (such as sarcasm or seriousness), partly because they found it hard to step outside their own perspective.
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doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9280.2007.01916.x

Papp, L. M., Cummings, E. M., & Goeke-Morey, M. C. (2009). *For richer, for poorer: Money as a topic of marital conflict in the home.* In home diary records of marital conflict, money was not the most frequent topic, but money conflicts were more pervasive, problematic and recurrent than other conflicts and more likely to stay unresolved.
doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3729.2008.00537.x

Rick, S. I., Small, D. A., & Finkel, E. J. (2011). *Fatal (fiscal) attraction: Spendthrifts and tightwads in marriage.* Tightwads and spendthrifts tend to marry each other; the bigger the difference within a couple, the more conflict over money, which in turn predicts lower marital wellbeing.
doi.org/10.1509/jmkr.48.2.228

Ross, M., & Sicoly, F. (1979). *Egocentric biases in availability and attribution.* In five experiments (married couples, groups, basketball teams), people recalled more of their own contributions to joint work and took more responsibility than others gave them; spouses' estimates of their own shares typically summed to more than 100 percent.
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doi.org/10.1037/0893-3200.22.3.389

Stone, D., Patton, B., & Heen, S. (1999). *Difficult Conversations: How to Discuss What Matters Most.* A practitioner book from the Harvard Negotiation Project describing three conversations inside every hard conversation (what happened, feelings, identity) and the gap between intent and impact.
penguinrandomhouse.com/books/331191/difficult-conversations-by-douglas-stone-bruce-patton-and-sheila-heen-foreword-by-roger-fisher

Taylor, M. J., McNicholas, C., Nicolay, C., Darzi, A., Bell, D., & Reed, J. E. (2014). *Systematic review of the application of the plan–do–study–act method to improve quality in healthcare.* Of 73 healthcare articles reporting the use of plan–do–study–act cycles, most did not report key features of the method, such as iterative cycles, small tests of change and real-time data.
doi.org/10.1136/bmjqs-2013-001862

Thibaut, J., & Walker, L. (1975). *Procedural Justice: A Psychological Analysis.* Founded procedural-justice research: people's judgments of whether a decision process is fair (especially having a voice) shape how satisfied they are with the outcome.
law.virginia.edu/node/127096

The monthly look-back

Boss, P. (1999). *Ambiguous loss: Learning to live with unresolved grief.* Named "ambiguous loss": losses without clear closure, such as someone physically absent but psychologically present, or present but psychologically changed (as in dementia), and suggested ways to cope.
bookshare.org/browse/book/2050897

Darley, J. M., & Latané, B. (1968). *Bystander intervention in emergencies: Diffusion of responsibility.* Students who heard another participant apparently having a seizure over an intercom were slower and less likely to report it when they believed other listeners were present, showing diffusion of responsibility.
doi.org/10.1037/h0025589

Dekker, S. (2007). *Just Culture: Balancing Safety and Accountability.* Argues for a "just culture" that separates honest mistakes from reckless behaviour, and that who draws the line matters as much as where it is drawn.
relbib.de/Record/1613173431

Deming, W. E. (1986). *Out of the Crisis.* Deming's case for quality management, arguing that most problems come from the system people work in rather than from individual workers.
eploes.lib2.uniwa.gr/Record/lib2_1%2F6426/Details?lng=el

Goodhart, C. A. E. (1975). *Problems of monetary management: The U.K. experience.* The original source of "Goodhart's law": a statistical regularity tends to break down once authorities put pressure on it for control purposes.
rba.gov.au/publications/rdp/1990/9013/conference-volumes.html

Hayslip, B., Jr., & Kaminski, P. L. (2005). *Grandparents raising their grandchildren: A review of the literature and suggestions for practice.* Reviewed research on custodial grandparents: the costs and benefits of raising a grandchild, how varied these families are, their need for social support, parenting, and help at several levels.
doi.org/10.1093/geront/45.2.262

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